

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF
MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SUNDAY 4 OCTOBER 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION



OCTOBER IS WHEN A SINGAPORE HOUSEHOLD BOOKS A JAPANESE WINTER (P21)

THE ATELIER

The same fan body, two motors. One idles at thirty-nine watts, the other at two, and the maker charges ten dollars more

THE KIT

Four hundred and ninety-nine dollars for twelve electrodes that score your concentration. The science page cites no study

THE DIARY

Four genuinely new rooms in Singapore, and not one of them has been reviewed by anyone who paid

THIS ISSUE • NO. 122

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FROM THE DESK

“For truth is rightly named the daughter of time, not of authority.”

Francis Bacon, *Novum Organum* (1620), Book I, Aphorism LXXXIV — in the next sentence, we are “unable, as if bewitched, to become familiar with things themselves”¹

Six desks this morning print a claim whose only source is the party making it.

THE STRIP • AT FRIDAY’S CLOSE		
US 2-year	4.46%	▼ 4bp
US 10-year	5.28%	▲ 11bp
10-year real	2.92%	▲ 9bp
VWRA	\$192.74	▼ 0.40%
DXY	101.93	▲ 0.95%
USD/SGD	1.2789	flat
Brent	\$102.25	▼ 1.98%
Gold	\$4,140.19	▼ 3.7%
Bitcoin (live)	\$84,684	▲ 0.68%

Weekly moves to Friday 2 October’s close; bitcoin live this morning. Detail on **p14**. Not advice.²

THE ARCHIVE • SUNDAY — THREE THINGS THIS MAGAZINE SAID THAT THE RECORD HAS SINCE CAUGHT UP WITH

No. 120 said the haze had broken. It had not; No. 121 corrected it at ninety-five. This morning the central region reads **102** — over the unhealthy line, and the first triple digit of this round. The correction was right and the forecast in it was still too kind (**p5**).

No. 121 called the oil release a coalition. Within forty-eight hours the American energy secretary was publicly attacking European governments for releasing “only a fraction” of what they pledged (**p3**).

We carried “ETIAS, Q4 2026” for weeks without reading it at the European source. There is no such date there, and the fee has gone from €7 to €20 (**p19**). A held thread that should have been chased sooner.³

SOURCES 1 Bacon’s *Novum Organum*, Book I, Aphorism LXXXIV, in the standard English translation, read at source; the following sentence is quoted from the same aphorism. 2 Levels at the close of 2 October 2026 and, for bitcoin, this morning; all sourced on **p14**. 3 Each item checked against the primary source named on the page cross-referenced.

THE WORLD · ONE PHOTOGRAPHER, TWO CAPITALS

A refinery burned south of Riyadh on Saturday. Sanaa says it did it; the coalition says nothing was hit. The only evidence either way is a French wire photograph

Aramco declined to comment and the energy ministry has said nothing. Markets closed before the fire started, so Monday is the first test of whether anyone believes it.

The fire is not in dispute. On **Saturday afternoon** an agency photographer south of the Saudi capital watched flames and black smoke rise from an Aramco refinery while firefighters worked it. A second wire found a witness describing “a large plume of smoke and fire.” **Aramco declined to comment.** The energy ministry has issued nothing. Everything after the fire is contested.¹

Hours later Sanaa claimed it: ballistic missiles and drones on “Aramco in the Saudi enemy capital,” in answer to **sixty Saudi airstrikes in twenty-four hours and 1,410 since the escalation began.** The coalition replied that the group’s losses make it “search for **imaginary victories.**” One capital says a refinery was struck; the other says nothing was. Neither is producing anything but a statement.²

RIYADH — ARAB NEWS / ASHARQ AL-AWSAT

“What the Houthis are experiencing in Taiz, and what we are witnessing in terms of human losses... makes them search for imaginary victories.” The same dispatch reports **257 precision operations** on Saturday and puts the group’s losses at **about 5,000 fighters in a week.**²

SANAA — AL MASIRAH

The strikes “**scored direct and accurate hits that set fire to the targeted sites.**” The doctrine, restated: **blockade-for-blockade, escalation-for-escalation.** The channel’s own English ticker that morning: “AFP: Firefighters are working to extinguish a fire at a Saudi Aramco facility in Riyadh.”³

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ATTACKS ON MERCHANT SHIPPING IN AND AROUND THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ **VERIFIED BY THE MARITIME ORGANISATION** SINCE THE WAR BEGAN ON 28 FEBRUARY, “RESULTING IN THE DEATHS OF AT LEAST **22 SEAFARERS**”⁴

THE SCEPTIC · THE WRONG KIND OF TARGET

The Riyadh plant is inland and serves the domestic market; it exports nothing. Ras Tanura — half a million barrels a day, an actual export hub — was struck twice in March and back on line in about a week. When the Houthis took out Saudi Arabia’s *only* Hormuz bypass last month, a named energy economist called the market response “**emotional... but it doesn’t seem at this point like a fundamental change.**” If a seven-million-barrel pipeline was not fundamental, an inland refinery is not. The tape agrees: Brent reached **\$108.75 on 15 September** and closed Friday at **\$102.25**, down six per cent while the war escalated continuously. And neither side’s arithmetic survives the other’s — Riyadh’s five thousand dead in a week sits against 110 documented casualties across all of September, and Sanaa published **94 strikes in 24 hours** that morning and **60 in 24 hours** that evening. What would settle it: a restart notice, or thermal imagery of burning tanks.⁵

THE CHATTER · THEY STOPPED ARGUING AND BUILT DASHBOARDS

Reddit refused this desk on every route again. The technical internet is **not discussing the war that is setting fire to its diesel:** a search of the main programmers’ board for stories tagged Yemen, Houthi, Hormuz or Saudi since 27 September returns **zero.** What it has built instead is instruments — a late-September “Show HN” offering an escalation score computed from oil reserves, shipping traffic and seismic data, on the stated grounds that the media “narrative can be crazy.” Six points, four comments. The one substantive reply, “**what are the weights in the score?**,” went unanswered, and a second user turned up to say he had built a rival live map with audible alerts.⁶

SOURCES 1 Agence France-Presse’s eyewitness account as published by France 24 and Kurdistan24, 3 October 2026; Reuters’ witness report as carried by Aaj English, in which Aramco declines comment; Al-Monitor noting no Saudi statement. 2 Arab News’ report of the coalition spokesman to Asharq Al-Awsat, published 23:14 Riyadh time, 3 October. 3 Al Masirah’s English service and its own front-page ticker, read 3 October. 4 The International Maritime Organization’s own press briefing. 5 Ras Tanura as previously reported here; the economist quoted in Newsweek’s September report on the pipeline strike; Brent settles from the daily futures series; casualty figures from Middle East Eye against the coalition’s; both Al Masirah counts of 3 October. The Riyadh plant’s capacity is *held*: one secondary source gives 130,000 b/d and no primary publishes it. 6 Hacker News search by date, and item 49834990.

THE WORLD · THE SHIPS NOBODY IS COUNTING

Five seafarers died when a hijacked tanker was retaken. The United Nations says they fell in the crossfire; the police force that stormed the ship says they were already dead

Somali piracy has come back and the two official tallies of how many people are still held do not agree — on the number, or on the names of the ships.

The MT HONOUR 25 was taken on 21 April with seventeen crew, most of them Pakistani, and 18,500 barrels of oil aboard. On 29 September, after a hundred and sixty-one days, it was retaken in Somali waters. **Five seafarers died.** The maritime organisation announced it on 2 October: **forty-four freed** from three vessels, **twenty-two still held** on a fourth. Its secretary-general said the five “reportedly died in the crossfire of rescue operations.”¹

The force that conducted the rescue says otherwise. Puntland’s information ministry, the day after: “Before the operation began, the pirates on board the ship killed five of the crew.” Three Pakistanis, one Myanmar national, one Indian; **sixteen suspected pirates captured.** Both statements are official, both on the record, four days apart. Nobody has reconciled them.²

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PIRACY CASES OFF SOMALIA SINCE APRIL, “WITH MORE THAN 100 CREWMEMBERS’ CAPTIVE,” BY THE EUROPEAN NAVAL MISSION’S OWN COUNT ON 11 SEPTEMBER. ITS NEWSROOM CARRIED **NOTHING AT ALL** ABOUT THE 29 SEPTEMBER RESCUE³

THE SCEPTIC · THE SUMS DO NOT CLOSE

Try to establish how many seafarers are held off northern Somalia this morning and you cannot. The EU mission’s July update gives **67 in captivity** — but its four vessel entries sum to **66** (17 + 15 + 12 + 22), each hedged “up to.” Worse, the two official lists do not describe the same ships. The mission names **SWARD**, St Kitts-flagged, fifteen crew, mostly Syrian. The maritime organisation names **SEAMULL**, also known as **SIBU 1**, and says the freed ships were seized “between April and August” — though none of the mission’s four was taken in August. The crew arithmetic (17 + 12 + 15 = 44) implies the two are one hull under two names, which this desk could not confirm. *Held.* No official body can currently tell you how many seafarers are held off northern Somalia, or what their ships are called.⁴

THE CHATTER · LIGHTS OFF, RADIO OFF, ONE IN TWENTY

A Filipino master in his early forties runs a three-hundred-metre tanker through Hormuz with navigation lights and radio switched off, in about a hundred metres of water off Oman. “**I’m just lucky because I still remember the traditional navigation, the old school.**” One owner is offering an extra six months’ pay to crew the run. Shipping executives put the odds of being hit on a crossing at roughly **one in twenty**. One bank still counts **17.5 million barrels a day** going through.⁵

ALSO MOVING

Mekelle changed hands on 3 October. Federal forces entered the Tigrayan capital after the TPLF abandoned it; the airport fell to pro-government militia on Friday. Fighting began **23 September**. The delta on our Thursday item: after Ethiopia expelled ten Eritrean diplomats and closed its Asmara embassy, **Eritrea severed relations entirely**, and Cairo reciprocated the Egyptian expulsion — with **Egypt, Eritrea, Somalia and Sudan due to meet in Egypt today.** Single-outlet as this desk has it.⁶

The bypass is still shut. Saudi Arabia’s only route around Hormuz — the Abqaiq-Yanbu pipeline, **seven million barrels a day of stated capacity** — closed as a “precautionary measure” on **11 September** after a drone strike the Saudi foreign ministry said came from Iraq. The Houthis took Mocha and the rest of Yemen’s Red Sea coast last month, which is why the Bab al-Mandab is now theirs (p3).⁷

SOURCES 1 The International Maritime Organization’s own press briefing of 2 October 2026, with the secretary-general’s statement and the vessel and crew counts. 2 Puntland’s information ministry via Garowe Online, 30 September. 3 EU Naval Force Operation ATALANTA’s update of 11 September; its newsroom, read 3 October, carries nothing on the rescue. 4 ATALANTA’s update of 29 July; the maritime organization’s briefing for the alternative names. The single-hull inference is ours and unconfirmed. 5 Bloomberg via gCaptain, 2 October. 6 France 24, 3 October. 7 Newsweek’s September report on the pipeline strike; Al-Monitor and Al Jazeera on the Red Sea coast.

SINGAPORE • THE FIVE-MINUTE TRAIN, IN FIFTY-NINE MORE DAYS

Nothing on the Causeway link is unbuilt. What slipped is the signature on the safety certificate

Two governments moved the opening to end-February. On the authority's own project page, forty-eight hours later, the train still opens this year.

On Friday 2 October the two transport ministries and the operator moved passenger service on the Johor Bahru–Singapore Rapid Transit System Link from **end-2026 to end-February 2027**. The operator still expects to finish system tests and trial runs by **31 December**. The extra two months are not construction — infrastructure on both sides is “substantially complete” — but **third-party safety certification and final approval by both grantors**. Malaysia's transport minister: “**There is a slight delay because, after completion, we still need certification from safety experts and regulators in both Malaysia and Singapore.**”¹

The line is **four kilometres**, Woodlands North to Bukit Chagar, **about five minutes**, rated at **10,000 commuters an hour each way at peak**. Note where the slip happened. The hard part — a viaduct across a strait, a customs hall, a train delivered in February — came in. What moved is the part no plan can schedule: two sovereign regulators signing the same piece of paper. *And this desk could not read that paper.* The land authority's own project page still carries the end-2026 target, stamped **5 May 2025**. The delay is firm in three outlets and absent from the primary record.²

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THE 24-HOUR INDEX IN THE CENTRAL REGION AT **FIVE O'CLOCK THIS MORNING**, FROM 95 AT THE SAME HOUR YESTERDAY. **OVER THE UNHEALTHY LINE**, WITH EAST 92 AND WEST 86 BEHIND IT. SUMATRA'S HOTSPOT COUNT WENT **127 TO 232** IN A DAY³

THE SCEPTIC • THIRTEEN DOLLARS, BORROWED

The quarterly tariff fell on 1 October to **28.59 cents a kilowatt-hour before tax**, from a record 31.91 — **down 10.4 per cent**, about **thirteen dollars a month** off a four-room flat. (Two outlets put it at \$12.99 and \$12.29; the cents are not worth printing.) The utility's stated reason was that Brent “had mostly stayed below the US\$90 mark between June and September.” **The futures record does not support September**. Brent settled **\$108.75 on the 15th and \$102.25 on the 2nd**, and is up **7.05 per cent on the month**; the sub-\$90 window was June to August. The next tariff is set off an October–December window that opened above \$100. A rear-view mirror with a bill attached.⁴

ALSO THIS WEEK

A ministry changed its name, and the proof is a redirect. From 1 October the Ministry of Trade and Industry became the **Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry** — type the old address and the server answers **301, moved to meti.gov.sg**. Same day it launched, with the World Bank, a three-year **ASEAN Power Grid Mobilisation Partnership** on cross-border electricity trade — no dollar figure, no gigawatt target and no named signatories in the web text.⁵

A held thread closes. Little India's **Festival Village runs 10 October to 8 November** on Campbell Lane — read at a listing, the organising body still publishing nothing. The street light-up was switched on at **seven last night at Birch Road**, an outdoor ceremony under a Central reading of 102. **September's manufacturing PMI was 51.7**, the best since October 2018; electronics 52.9, the best since January 2018.⁶

THE CHATTER • THE CYNICISM IS LOAD-BEARING

Reddit refused this desk again on every route, so the forum of record is the same hardware board as last week. Its thread on the delay opened at **11:51 on Friday morning**, ran to thirty-seven replies, and nobody is angry. “**It will delay, delay and delay. Stop dreaming.**” “I wouldn't be surprised if there were another one pushing it to mid 2027 or beyond.” And, asked whether the link changes anything: “**still many will go there**” — by bus and by car, as now. Elsewhere on the same board, a 10.4 per cent cut to everyone's power bill drew less traffic than a comparison of car-sharing fees. *Pseudonymous handles.*⁷

SOURCES 1 The 2 October joint announcement by the two transport ministries and the operator, via Mothership and Stomp, read 4 October 2026; the minister's words as quoted there. 2 The land authority's own project page, read 4 October: still end-2026, stamped 5 May 2025, and the source of the length, journey time and capacity. Its newsroom index stops in April 2021. 3 The environment agency's real-time data interface at 05:00 on 4 October, published 05:31; hotspot counts from the regional meteorological centre as reported. Its haze site returned 503. 4 The utility's tariff page (22.18 + 6.10 + 0.23 + 0.08); Yahoo Singapore and AsiaOne for the household figures; Brent settles from the daily futures series. 5 The redirect observed directly; the ministry's newsroom. 6 A dated community listing; Trading Economics for both indices, the association's PDF still password-encrypted. 7 HardwareZone, 4 October 2026.

THE ATELIER · ELECTRIC FANS AND AIR CIRCULATORS

The same fan body, two motors: one idles at thirty-nine watts, the other at two. The maker charges ten dollars more for the second

Almost no fan sold in Singapore publishes a comparable airflow figure. In Europe the law requires one, which is how you know the number exists and is being withheld.

Start at the motor; everything else is downstream of it. Vornado sells one body, the 633, with two. The AC induction version draws **62, 45 and 39 watts** across three fixed notches and moves **899, 732 and 484 cubic feet a minute** at **56, 51 and 45 decibels**. The brushless DC version, same body, runs **99 speeds from 40 watts down to 2**, moves 1,008 CFM at the top, and costs **ten US dollars more**.¹

Then geometry. A circulator is a short, deep-shrouded propeller behind a spiral grille: it throws a tight column that bounces off the far wall and stirs the whole room. An oscillating pedestal fan sweeps a wide slow fan of air at you and nothing at the room. All real engineering — and **almost nobody publishes the number that would let you compare them**. Europe forces it: a comfort fan sold there must declare flow rate, power, a service value in cubic metres per minute per watt, and sound power.²

2W vs 39W

LOWEST-SPEED DRAW, SAME FAN BODY, TWO MOTORS. AT TEN HOURS A DAY ON THIS QUARTER'S TARIFF OF 31.16 CENTS A UNIT INCLUDING TAX, THAT IS **\$S2.27 A YEAR AGAINST \$S44.36** — OUR COMPUTATION, FOR A TEN-DOLLAR DIFFERENCE AT PURCHASE³

THE MAKERS, BY NAME — AND WHO REALLY BUILDS THEM

Vornado (Kansas, 1945) publishes CFM and watts per speed and gives **five years** on every model checked; the Singapore distributor sells the 6303DC at **\$S229** in 220–240V. **Balmuda's** GreenFan lists at **¥39,600**, street **¥24,970** — and its own listing prospectus says the company **“is a fabless manufacture... purchases most of its products from contract manufacturers in China and Taiwan,”** the GreenFan being the stated exception. **KDK** — the badge every Singapore electrician specifies — built Japan's first mass-produced fan in **1913** and has belonged to **Panasonic since 1956**; 48-inch DC ceiling fans run **\$S378**. **Mistral** belongs to the Malaysian group **Khind**. **Lasko and Air King are one company**.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE MONEY STOPS BUYING AIR

Balmuda's own prospectus says its prices run **“double to ten times the prices of conventional products.”** By our sums the GreenFan's street price is **4.25 times** a Koizumi in the same twenty-watt DC class, **6.7 times** at list. Dyson at \$S329 against the Vornado 6303DC at \$S229 moves about the same air on maker figures — 1,059 against 1,051 CFM — on more watts. Bladeless is not inefficient: there is a brushless motor and an impeller in there. But it is a safety and cleaning story, not an efficiency one.⁵

THE SINGAPORE REALITY, AND WHAT KILLS THEM

Do not import the American one. Vornado's US AC models are 120V, 60Hz; a transformer fixes voltage, not frequency, and a motor built for sixty hertz turns at about five-sixths of its speed on fifty. Japanese domestic units are 100V and, per one maker's datasheet, **“designed for use in Japan only... No servicing is available outside of Japan.”** What fails, in order: dust in the housing; then bearings — **“once bearing damaged it is irreversible”**; then a capacitor. In this climate that makes **a grille that unscrews** a specification, not a nicety.⁶

NEXT ON THE BENCH — YOU PICK TOMORROW'S CATEGORY

Espresso machines (the boiler, not the badge) — heat exchanger against dual boiler against lever, and the point where the price-to-cup curve goes flat.

Travel tripods & heads — the argument is the locking mechanism and the head, never the leg count; and one conglomerate owns most of the names.

Hand-knit & boot socks — a daily-wear object where the buy-once claim is testable against a published lifetime guarantee.

SOURCES 1 Vornado's pages for the 633 and 633DC: wattage, airflow and decibels per speed, prices, and the 99-speed figure from its Australian distributor. The efficiency ratios are ours from those tables. 2 The same pages for throw; Balmuda's page for the dual blade; EU Regulation 206/2012, Annex I, for the declaration requirement. 3 SP Group's tariff page; the annual costs are our computation at ten hours a day. 4 Vornado's warranty terms and its Singapore distributor; Balmuda's prospectus of December 2020; KDK's corporate history; Khind's filings; Air King's site; Crestar's site and Courts. 5 As above; kakaku.com for the Koizumi price; the Haiku's energy label. 6 Maker datasheets; the 50Hz figure derives from induction-motor principle; failure modes from a HardwareZone thread, handle pseudonymous.

TECHNOLOGY · SOVEREIGN, FOR SEVENTEEN MORE DAYS

Germany shipped a “sovereign” open-weight model on Reunification Day. Its maker had signed, a fortnight earlier, to merge into a Canadian company and trade under that company’s name

Seventy-eight billion parameters, Apache-licensed, trained on European soil — and no independent evaluation of it exists anywhere.

The launch post opens: “On the Day of German Reunification, we are releasing our new model.” Kolibri is 78.1 billion parameters total, 3.46 billion active per token — 4.4 per cent — across 384 experts and fifty layers. Apache 2.0. It was pre-trained on 768 Blackwell GPUs for twenty-one days, finishing 11 September, “in Germany and Finland, under European and German law, with no foreign control.”¹

On 16 September — seventeen days before the release — the company signed a “definitive business combination agreement” with Cohere. The unified firm will operate globally as Cohere, headquartered in Berlin and Toronto, closing later this year. Twelve days after that its co-chief executive left after fourteen months.²

0.8 and 1.0

THE POINTS BY WHICH KOLIBRI BEATS ITS NEAREST SPARSE RIVAL IN ENGLISH AND GERMAN, BY ITS OWN 189-PAGE REPORT. THE SAME REPORT, §3.3.3: “QWEN3.8 27B HAS THE HIGHEST OVERALL AGGREGATES”³

THE SCEPTIC · THE REPORT ARGUES AGAINST ITSELF, HONESTLY

Credit where due: the dissent is *in the document*. Kolibri’s claim is not to be the best model but the best **sparse** one — 3.46 billion active parameters against twenty-seven billion. On the base model the report says plainly that it “ranks second on both Overall aggregates.” The weak columns are published too: **39.8 on multi-turn function calling against 58.2, 27.7 on a terminal benchmark against 39.7**. The strong ones are maths and agentic work — **96.0 on AIME**, 66.4 on SWE-Bench Verified. What is missing is anyone else’s arithmetic.⁴

THE CHATTER · FOUR HUNDRED AND NINE POINTS ON WHAT THE WORD MEANS

The thread ran to 262 comments and the argument was not about benchmarks. One commenter asked how a soon-to-be-Canadian-owned company is sovereign; a staff member answered: “**Sovereignty is imho mostly about choice and control over your data.**” Another was blunter: “you’d be better off just downloading Chinese LLMs, even if you get cut off you still have the weights.” A third, on the model: “**This thing is worse than a Qwen3.8 27B**” — met with the Pareto-frontier reply. A fourth asked it how to run itself and found **abstention training had taught it to refuse**: “It doesn’t know.” A fifth caught it citing a superseded German statute. *Pseudonymous handles.*⁵

STILL ON THE SHELF

Memory gets worse before it gets better. A Micron executive’s warning that supply will be “much tighter in 2027 and 2028 than in 2026” drew **390 points and 439 comments** on the same board on 1 October, with a follow-up the next day. This desk could not read either underlying article — one host returned 403, the other is blocked — so the claim is **held at headline level only**, and the circulating “50 to 67 per cent of demand” figure traces to a December 2025 earnings call, not to this week.⁶

SOURCES 1 Aleph Alpha’s launch post of 3 October 2026 and its 189-page technical report, text extracted from the published PDF: parameter counts, expert and layer configuration, training hardware and duration, jurisdiction, token mix, licence and weight format. The blog gives 20 trillion pre-training tokens where the report gives 24 trillion across all stages; the report does not name the datacentre operator. 2 The company’s newsroom, 16 and 28 September 2026. 3 The technical report, §3.3.3 and Table 28. 4 The same report; the most-read independent write-up and its author’s disclosure; the one other outlet covering the release. 5 Hacker News item 49942706, 409 points, 262 comments. 6 Hacker News item 49920932; the underlying articles were unreadable — one host 403, the other blocked.

THE HOME LAB • A SPEED-UP, A REGRESSION, A FIX, IN THIRTY HOURS

The sovereign German model's first working local build ran on a five-year-old Mac laptop chip. There is still no build for the engine most self-hosters use

And if you run n-gram drafting above temperature zero, do not pull master this week: the merge that sped up sampling knocked a third off one user's tokens a second.

Merged on 2 October: an option that replaces greedy acceptance of draft tokens with proper rejection sampling — accept with probability $\min(1, p/q)$, resample the rejects. The author's own measurements, on a 5090 and on a Spark: **+5.21 per cent mean throughput at temperature 0.5 to 1.0**, rising to **+14.65 per cent at temperature 1.0**; across five models on multi-token prediction, **+2.83 to +7.24 per cent**. **At temperature zero the gain is exactly nothing** — it only helps sampled output. Three maintainers approved it. **No third party reproduced it.**¹

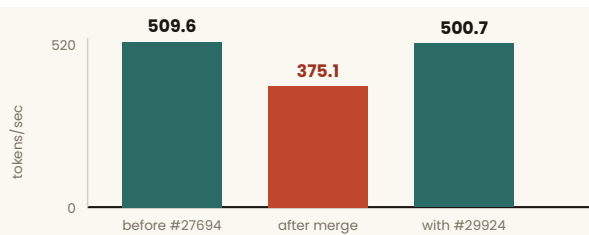
The next day a user reported a model running n-gram drafting at temperature 0.7 falling “from about 55 tokens a second to 23 to 35.” Truncated n-gram drafts were being rejected outright. The same author's fix, measured on a 5090: **509.6 tokens a second before the merge**, **375.1 after**, **500.7 with the fix**. The reporter confirmed it. **That fix is still open**. If you run n-gram drafting above temperature zero, hold off pulling until it lands.²

1.55×

DECODE SPEED-UP FROM THE MULTI-TOKEN-PREDICTION MERGE OF 1 OCTOBER, ACCEPTANCE 0.640, RANGE 1.43 TO 1.67 ACROSS CATEGORIES — **STILL MEASURED ON EXACTLY ONE RIG**, THREE ISSUES AFTER WE FIRST SAID SO. IT IS ALSO A BREAKING CHANGE: EXISTING QUANTISATIONS OF THE MODEL STOP WORKING³

THE CHATTER • THE MAC GOT THERE FIRST

Within hours of Kolibri's release (p7) there were **six community quantisations** on the model hub: five for Apple's framework, one NVFP4, and **no GGUF at all**. The four-bit Apple build is **44.3 gigabytes**, peaks at 44 of 48 on a short prompt, and “fits 64GB+ Macs”; it was converted on an **M1 Max with 64 gigabytes**, its author reporting **about 52 to 56 tokens a second** — self-reported, unreproduced. The request for support in the C++ engine everyone else uses was opened on 3 October and has **zero comments**, **no maintainer reply** and **no linked pull request**.⁴



Thirty hours. One author's measurements on an RTX 5090, Llama-3.1-8B Q4_K_M at temperature 0.7, through the merge that broke n-gram drafting and the fix that is still open. Meridian original, plotted from the figures in the two pull requests.

THE SCEPTIC • “A VIBE CODED KNOCK OFF”

A narrow MIT-licensed C inference engine from a well-known author reached the board on 2 October at **336 points**, supporting a handful of models on 64GB-plus Apple silicon, a Spark, or a Strix Halo desktop. The warm read: “it only supports a small set of carefully chosen models, but it supports them really well.” The cold one: **“It's apparently a vibe coded knock off of llama.cpp.”** And the thread drifted, as these do, to what the hardware costs: “7800€ for a MacBook Pro M5 Max with 128GB RAM, right now. Insane,” against “anyone who didn't buy a 128GB Strix Halo system when they were 2500€ has only themselves to blame.” Which is the memory squeeze on p7 arriving in a shopping basket.⁵

SOURCES 1 llama.cpp pull request 27694, merged 2 October 2026, read at its own page: the sampling change, the author's benchmark tables and hardware, and the approvals. 2 The regression report in that thread of 3 October, and pull request 29924, open at press, with its before/after measurements. 3 Pull request 29761, merged 1 October, for the 1.55× figure, acceptance rate, per-category range and the breaking-change note. 4 The model hub's quantisation listing for Kolibri; the Apple-framework model card for size, memory and self-reported speed; llama.cpp issue 29922, opened 3 October with no replies; pull request 29831, merged 3 October, for the contrast case. 5 Hacker News item 49936575, 336 points, 97 comments; the project's site for its model list and hardware targets; frame.work returned 403.

THE KIT · A NUMBER ABOUT YOUR HEAD

Four hundred and ninety-nine dollars for twelve electrodes that score your concentration. The maker's own science page cites no study

The Neurable One ships this month, to America only. Nobody outside the company has measured anything about it — and when two labs weighed its predecessor they came forty grams apart.

The headphone has forty-millimetre beryllium drivers, and that is the least interesting thing about it. Woven into the ear pads of the **Neurable One** are **twelve dry EEG sensors, six a side**, reading at **sixteen bits across a 125Hz bandwidth**. They return six things — calmness, cognitive load, cognitive speed, focus, wakefulness, the raw bands — as an exportable spreadsheet. **US\$499, 345g**, twenty-two hours of music or twelve with the brain-reading on. Ships this month, **United States only**.¹

Every figure in that paragraph is the manufacturer's. **No independent laboratory has touched this product**. It is absent from the index of the site that weighs and graphs headphones for a living; a second testing outfit's search returns nothing; the engineering board where such a thing gets argued about has no thread since April last year. The one checkable number disagrees: the trade report of the launch gives the front end as **twenty-four bits**; the maker says sixteen.²

338g vs 378g

THE SAME PREDECESSOR HEADPHONE, WEIGHED BY TWO REVIEW OUTFITS. FORTY GRAMS APART ON AN OBJECT EITHER COULD HAVE PUT ON THE SCALES TWICE³

That predecessor — the same sensors in another brand's cup — is the only measured record there is. One lab got perceived-loudness reduction of **74 per cent** and the claimed twenty-eight hours delivered; it scored the thing 7.2 and **declined to call the brain-reading pseudoscience**. A second outlet, same model, got eight or nine real hours, patchy contact over hair, and an app that dropped out.³

THE CHATTER · THE ENGINEERS WHO ARGUE ABOUT ELECTRODES

The best discussion of this company is an old fifty-six-point thread on a programmers' board. For: a poster crediting it with **"a unique approach to signal processing which allows them to get good signal-to-noise compared to most other scalp EEG headsets."** Against, the compression objection: **"Running a PCA on data from 64 node** (wet contact, shaved head, lab environment) **shows that you basically get one channel of data"** — said of a rig with five times the electrodes and conductive gel.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · SELLS A NUMBER, PUBLISHES NONE

The science page names a **2011 university signal-processing breakthrough**, gestures at whitepapers and proprietary AI, and gives **no study, no journal, no sample size and no accuracy figure** for any of the six metrics. The regulatory line is carried plainly — not a medical device, diagnoses nothing — and is beside the point: the question is not whether a focus score is a diagnosis, but whether it is a measurement. A second objection has nothing to do with neuroscience.⁵

ALSO ON THE BENCH

A display with the projector deleted. A Japanese component maker showed glasses optics on 2 October that paint the image **straight onto the retina** through a meta-optic mirror **150 nanometres thick** at roughly **80 per cent transmittance**. Monochrome prototype; brightness, field of view, power and daylight behaviour **all undisclosed**. Shown publicly from **13 October**.⁶

The conferencing headset is the repairable one. Logitech's Zone Vibe Pro, 3 October, **US\$259.99**, ships with user-replaceable **batteries, ear pads and headband straps** — a spec no flagship consumer can has matched this year.⁷

Still on the shelf. Technics' EAH-A1000 reaches a fourth issue **with no Singapore price**; so does Nothing's Headphone (1) Pro, whose claimed 327g this desk measured at 383.5g. The FoKus Artemis is unmeasured for a third issue.⁸

SOURCES 1 Neurable's storefront page and product JSON: price, shipping restriction, mass, sensor count, bit depth, bandwidth, battery, metrics, CSV export. 2 Notebookcheck's 2 October launch report, which gives twenty-four bits; RTINGS' index and SoundGuys' search, both returning no Neurable product; Hacker News, nothing since April 2025. Head-Fi served a bot challenge. 3 SoundGuys' measured review of the Master & Dynamic MW75 Neuro, 8 November 2024; Gizmodo's Japanese edition on the same model. 4 Hacker News item 23144744. 5 Neurable's science page and its storefront's processing and retention statements. 6 Japanese edition on the same model. 4 Hacker News item 23144744. 5 Neurable's science page and its storefront's processing and retention statements. 6 Notebookcheck, 2 October, on the TDK demonstration. 7 Notebookcheck, 3 October, on the Logitech launch. 8 Meridian Nos. 118–121.

THE GOOD LIFE · A SIGNATURE, AND AN ABSENCE

Hanhart has licensed Steve McQueen's name for a chronograph. The watch the licence refers to has never been found

Three hundred pieces, sold out inside two days – and the same reference carries two maker-published prices twenty-six per cent apart.

The object is good. The Hanhart 417 ES Steve McQueen Limited Edition No. 1, announced 1 October, is 39mm across, 13.3mm tall with its domed crystal and 11.55 without, on a 46mm lug-to-lug steel case, 100m, fluted bidirectional bezel, the house's red pusher at four. Inside, a hand-wound Sellita AMT5100 M: column wheel, flyback, 23 jewels, 4Hz, 58 hours, uncertified, to the maker's own zero to plus eight seconds a day. Three hundred pieces.¹

What it costs depends on which of the maker's pages you open. The European launch price, carried identically by three watch titles, is €2,890 including nineteen per cent German VAT – €2,428 net. The same reference on Hanhart's own English storefront is US\$4,260, "incl."²

US\$368

THE MCQUEEN PREMIUM OVER HANHART'S OWN PLAIN 417 ES 1954 FLYBACK 39MM, ON THE SAME STOREFRONT IN THE SAME CURRENCY. NINE AND A HALF PER CENT, FOR A SIGNATURE ABOVE THE SIX AND A BOTTLE OF RED NAIL POLISH³

THE SCEPTIC · A LICENCE TO A WATCH NOBODY CAN PRODUCE

The provenance is photographs. A Paris Match frame from the 1964 ISDT in East Germany and a photographer's pictures at Palm Springs in May 1963: that is the documentary record of McQueen wearing a Hanhart. The retailer that assembled it also records the hole in it – "while the provenance of his Heuer Monacos and his Rolex Submariners have been well documented, the fate of his Hanhart is unknown." A maker has bought the right to put a dead man's signature on a watch whose original cannot be examined, dated, or located. Second, the catalogue: Hanhart's own site lists twenty-eight products across the 417 ES and 415 ES lines, several already mining this one man. Third, the name: "No. 1" commits the brand to a No. 2, and a numbered series of licensed editions is a subscription in the costume of scarcity.⁴

THE CHATTER · FOUR WORDS FROM THE FORUM, AND THEY ARE THE REVIEW

It sold out before the collectors woke up, so there is almost nothing to read. The board where this argument belongs now sits behind a paywall that returned this desk HTTP 402, Payment Required – but the thread title was visible, and the title is the community's settled posture written by them: "Hanhart did it again: Another 417 launched today."⁵

ALSO ON THE SHELF

The only watch this week a Singaporean can walk in and buy. Seiko's Prospex Diver "Blue Tears" HBB006, 2 October: S\$953.80, 1,200 pieces, sold only in Singapore, Hong Kong, Macau, Malaysia and Brunei. 41.7 × 12.3mm, 200m, calibre 4R35, 21,600vph, 41 hours; Hardlex, not sapphire. And Seiko publishes no page of its own for it – the Singapore site 404s on the reference. The one Singapore price in this column exists only in the press.⁶

Thirty milliseconds. Patek Philippe's ref. 5978P, Milan, 1 October: 42 × 14.45mm platinum, calibre CH 29-535 PS QI, a perpetual calendar whose whole date, day, month and leap-year display changes over in thirty thousandths of a second. €315,500 before tax, 120 pieces, Italian retailers only.⁷

Eight pieces. Armin Strom's Tribute³ Au750: 38mm of solid rose gold, 9.38mm tall, around a 4.2mm hand-wound calibre with a hundred-hour reserve and two patterns cut by hand. CHF 69,000.⁸

SOURCES 1 Hanhart's page for ref. H705L.210–2110: dimensions, movement, frequency, reserve, rate tolerance, edition size, sold-out status. 2 The same page for the dollar figure; Monochrome, SJX and Fratello, 1–3 October, each publishing €2,890 incl. 19% VAT. The euro conversion is ours at Friday's cross. 3 Hanhart's 417 ES category page: the plain 1954 Flyback 39mm at US\$3,892, same storefront, same currency. 4 The Rake's account of the 1964 ISDT photographs, including the sentence quoted; Hanhart's category listing for the count. 5 WatchUSeek, which returned HTTP 402 – thread title only; Monochrome's comment threads on the Hanhart and on the Raymond Weil Milleseime Jubilee Chronograph (CHF 3,895, 500 pieces). 6 SJX, 2 October; seikowatches.com/sg-en, 404 on the reference. 7 SJX, 1 October, from Milan. 8 Monochrome, 2 October.

SCREEN & SOUND • TWO FILMS, ONE SCORE

The critics gave them the same mark. One cost forty million dollars and took fifteen; the other cost a hundred and twenty-five and took three

Verity and *Digger* both scored forty-five on Metacritic on Friday. Audiences rated the one they skipped higher.

The aggregate is a stand-in for a verdict, and on Friday it stopped standing in. *Verity* — Michael Showalter’s adaptation of the Colleen Hoover novel, with Anne Hathaway, Dakota Johnson and Josh Hartnett — opened on 3,510 screens and took \$15,102,000, on top of \$4.5m in Thursday previews. Against a \$40m budget that is 49 per cent recovered in forty-eight hours. *Digger* — Alejandro González Iñárritu directing Tom Cruise, shot by Emmanuel Lubezki, \$125m — opened on 3,321 and took \$3,400,000. Per theatre: \$4,303 against \$1,024.¹

Both films carry a Metascore of 45. *Verity*’s comes from 32 critics, *Digger*’s from 56. On the percentage scale they separate — *Digger* 51 per cent of 247, *Verity* 34 per cent of 128 — which is the ordinary gap between a pass-fail count and a weighted average, not a disagreement. *Digger*’s critics split 27 per cent positive, 46 mixed, 27 negative: a film nobody could place. And the audience scores invert the box office. *Digger*: 72 per cent, user 6.8. *Verity*: 70 per cent, user 4.4. The people who went to the cheaper film liked it least.²

4.44×

VERITY’S FRIDAY OVER DIGGER’S, ON A BUDGET ONE THIRD THE SIZE. DIGGER’S WORLDWIDE TOTAL AFTER TWO DAYS, INCLUDING A 30 SEPTEMBER FRENCH AND BELGIAN START, IS \$7.4M — 5.9 PER CENT OF ITS PRODUCTION BUDGET¹

THE CHATTER • THE SPLIT IS THE VERDICT

There is no consensus to report, which is the report. On the aggregator’s own user pages *Digger*’s defenders file it beside *Dr. Strangelove* and its detractors call it one of the worst things they have sat through — the 27/46/27 critic spread reproduced exactly in the stalls, twenty-one points above its critics’ score. *Verity*’s audience did the opposite: they bought the ticket because they had read the book, then rated it 4.4 out of ten. Nobody loves either film. One of them had a readership attached.³

THE SCEPTIC • TWO DAYS IS NOT A WEEKEND

This desk should say so before anyone extrapolates from the table above. Saturday’s chart is not posted — the tracker’s 3 October page returns “no data available” and no weekend estimate exists at press. A book adaptation front-loads its pre-sold readership into Friday and typically falls on Saturday; a star-driven adult drama can hold. The gap will narrow, and by how much is the only interesting number of the weekend.⁴

IN BRIEF

Two accounting systems, one film. The Avengers re-release stands at \$32,926,985 on one tracker, which counts the encore as its own title, and at \$891,299,985 on day 2,717 on another, which folds it into the 2019 original. Same Friday, same picture, a \$858m difference in what you call it. The crediting problem this desk flagged in No. 117 is unresolved.¹

Resident Evil crossed \$116.0m domestic on its fifteenth day, up 104 per cent Friday on Friday; **Spider-Man: Brand New Day** sits at \$952,606,970. Friday’s whole box office, seventeen reporting titles, was \$32,865,474 — just over twice what *Verity* alone took.¹

No score to print. The Indianapolis dream-pop band Wishy released *Nature’s Pill* on 2 October; three separate critic aggregators refused this desk, so the album runs here without a number rather than with a borrowed one. No Japanese or Korean release landed in the window at all, and Japan’s own weekend chart is not out.⁵

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo’s daily chart for 2 October 2026 and The Numbers’ daily chart for the same date, which agree on every figure; The Numbers’ title pages for both films’ production budgets and *Digger*’s international start. Box Office Mojo’s 3 October page returns no data. 2 Metacritic’s pages for both films, read 3 October 2026, for the Metascores, critic counts and the positive/mixed/negative splits; Rotten Tomatoes for the Tomatometer, critic counts and Popcornmeter. 3 Metacritic critic and user pages for both titles; the 80 is Screen Rant, the 20 is /Film. 4 As 1 and 2. 5 Release Wave’s October 2026 archive; Metacritic’s music browse, AlbumOfTheYear and Pitchfork each returned 403 or were unreachable. Box Office Mojo carries no Japanese weekend-40 data.

THE FAMILY DESK • THE MACHINE THAT NEVER GETS BORED OF YOU

Eight per cent of twelve- to fourteen-year-olds have asked a chatbot for help with their feelings. Among those who have, nearly two in three told nobody

The alarming figure everyone repeats and the sober one in the journals are measuring different things. Only one of them is about a twelve-year-old.

Anationally representative survey of 1,009 Americans aged twelve to twenty-one, published in a paediatrics journal in June, asked whether they had ever used an AI chatbot for mental-health advice. 19.2 per cent of the whole sample had. But the figure is steeply age-graded, and the band that contains a twelve-year-old is the lowest: 8 per cent at twelve to fourteen, against 21 at fifteen to seventeen and 24.1 at eighteen to twenty-one — an adjusted odds ratio of 3.65 (1.98–6.74) for the oldest band over the youngest. Among those who had, 42.8 per cent used it monthly or more, 91.7 per cent found the advice helpful, and 63.3 per cent told nobody. It is cross-sectional. It establishes nothing about cause.¹

A March survey of 1,204 American children aged nine to seventeen, margin of error 3.8 points, fills in the band below. At nine to twelve: 81 per cent use AI at all, 58 per cent have used a chatbot, 17 per cent use one daily. Asked who they would go to first about their feelings, 56 per cent said a trusted adult, 32 a friend, 5 a chatbot; about their health or body, 73 per cent an adult and 9 per cent of the nine-to-twelves a chatbot. The uncomfortable half: 16 per cent of nine-to-twelve-year-old users say a chatbot showed them something that was not meant for someone their age — and of those shown it, 53 per cent told no adult.²

41%

OF CHILDREN WHO USE AI SAY THEIR PARENTS HAVE NEVER TALKED TO THEM ABOUT USING IT SAFELY, IN THE SAME SURVEY IN WHICH 56 PER CENT OF PARENTS ARE REPORTED TO HAVE DONE SO²

THE SCEPTIC • THE BEST CAUSAL EVIDENCE FOUND NOTHING

Before anyone panics: the strongest design yet run on this question is a pre-registered randomised controlled trial, and it is a null. 183 people, randomised to ten minutes a day with a companion chatbot or ten minutes of text word games, twenty-one days, four surveys and two interview rounds. No overall effect on social health, loneliness or human relationships against control. The only signal was a mediation path: those who most wanted connection anthropomorphised the bot more, and those people reported more spillover. Two further strands point the same way — a 14,721-adult survey associating companion use with higher wellbeing, and a six-country survey of 5,663 finding distress predicts use rather than the reverse. This desk read those two only in a policy brief's summary, not at source. The counterweight, for honesty: a two-wave study of 1,182 chatbot users found sustained companionship predicting lower wellbeing a year on, "mainly explained by lower in-person social interaction" — observational, adult-skewed, a proposed pathway rather than a demonstrated one. General guidance, not medical advice.³

THE CHATTER • WHAT PARENTS CAN SEE, AND WHAT THEY CANNOT

Reddit is unreachable from this desk, so we read it through a paper that coded 1,628 posts from parenting and teenage communities, 2023 to 2026. Teenagers write about emotional support — 31 per cent of their posts against 19 per cent of parents'. Parents write about romantic and sexual interaction — 36 against 25. The gap that matters: benefits from emotional support appear in 27 per cent of teenagers' posts and 5 per cent of parents'. The authors' explanation is about visibility, not disagreement. A four-hour nightly conversation looks like dependence; intimate content surfaces in a log; an ordinary, helpful two-minute "I had a bad day" reaches a parent by neither route. And the children are not oblivious: attachment is the risk teenagers themselves name most often, at 19 per cent, against parents' 16%.⁴

SOURCES 1 "AI Chatbot Use and Disclosure for Mental Health Among US Adolescents and Young Adults," *JAMA Pediatrics*, 1 June 2026, 180(8):884–890, full text read in the public archive: design, unweighted n, age bands, adjusted odds ratios with confidence intervals, and the disclosure and helpfulness figures. The authors' own caveat is that perceived helpfulness "may reflect AI chatbots' tendencies toward sycophancy and overflattery." 2 The 2026 Common Sense Media census of AI use by tweens and teens, fielded 18–26 March 2026, N=1,204, margin of error ±3.8 points; PDF downloaded and read. 3 Guingrich & Graziano, arXiv 2509.19515, the twenty-one-day randomised trial; the two supporting surveys as summarised in a Center for AI Policy brief, not read at source; Zhang et al., arXiv 2609.07243, for the longitudinal counterweight. 4 Berkane et al., arXiv 2609.20720, 17 September 2026, coding 1,628 Reddit posts.

THE FAMILY DESK • THE YEAR THEY BANNED IT

Ten months into Australia's under-sixteen social-media ban, daily use among twelve- and thirteen-year-olds has gone from fifty-one per cent to forty-nine

Of those still on YouTube, sixty-four per cent say the platform did nothing to their account at all. The ban was mostly not circumvented. It was mostly not applied.

The law took effect on 10 December 2025, with civil penalties to A\$49.5 million and ten platforms assessed as age-restricted. The first serious evaluation, published in a medical journal in June, used a regression discontinuity at the age-sixteen threshold on 408 adolescents followed from just before implementation to three months after — 94 per cent retention, mean age 14.33.¹

The age bands tell it better than the estimate does. Twelve- and thirteen-year-olds went 51 per cent to 49; fourteen- and fifteen-year-olds 78 to 69; the sixteen-plus group the law exempts went 80 to 89. More than 85 per cent of under-sixteen participants were still using restricted platforms at follow-up, mostly on their own accounts.¹

64%

OF AUSTRALIAN TWELVE- TO FIFTEEN-YEAR-OLDS STILL USING YOUTUBE WHO SAID NO ACTION AT ALL HAD BEEN TAKEN AGAINST THE ACCOUNT THEY ALREADY HAD. ONLY ABOUT A QUARTER HAD TO BEAT AN AGE CHECK; VPN USE WAS FOUR TO FIVE PER CENT²

THE CHATTER • THE CHILDREN'S OWN SURVEY, AND THE GAP IT EXPOSES

A March poll of 1,050 Australians aged twelve to fifteen — advocacy-commissioned, and we say so — found 61 per cent of those who previously held restricted accounts still had one active, and 70 per cent calling it “easy” to get round. The honest half is the wellbeing split: of previous users, 45 per cent report no impact on their mental health, 33 per cent positive, 19 per cent negative; on sleep, 38 per cent positive against 12; and on understanding what is going on in the world, 29 per cent negative against 26 positive — the one line that is net worse.²

THE SCEPTIC • AND THE PRECEDENT NOBODY CITES

Two pieces of real dissent, pointing opposite ways. Against the ban's premise: the best Australian pre-implementation data is cross-sectional, 365 dyads, mean age 12.8, and its effects are small — anxiety associated with ever having used social media at $\beta=1.00$ (0.45–1.55), one point on a twenty-one-point scale. One author sits on the regulator's own advisory group evaluating this legislation, which the paper declares. That study also found 75 per cent intended to circumvent the restrictions — predicted, then observed. Against expecting any ban to work: South Korea's 2011 midnight gaming shutdown, on evaluation, raised sleep by 1.5 minutes a child and cut internet addiction by 0.7 percentage points, and was discontinued. Cited in the charity's briefing, not read at source. The sharpest note is procedural: the bill had 36 hours of public comment, and judging it by accounts deleted rather than by the outcome it was sold on is a category error. General guidance, not medical advice.³

AND IT ARRIVES HERE IN 2027

Singapore's model, in a ministry's reply to a parliamentary question on 8 September, is tiered, not a ban: under-thirteens may not hold accounts on designated services, with age assurance; thirteen- to seventeen-year-olds keep access behind mandated safeguards — no messages from strangers, restricted autoplay, and a default daily time limit per platform parents may adjust. Six services are named, including the local forum this magazine keeps quoting. Legislation in 2027, with non-complying platforms liable to have their minimum age raised to eighteen. A child born in July 2014 is in the under-thirteen tier now and crosses into the safeguarded one in July 2027 — roughly when the law is expected to land.⁴

SOURCES 1 Barnes et al., “Assessing early effects of Australia's Social Media Minimum Age Act on adolescents' social media use,” *The BMJ*, 24 June 2026, 393:e363695, full text read in the public archive: design, retention, discontinuity estimates with confidence intervals, the age-band tables and the authors' stated limitations. Penalty and platform figures from a law firm's May 2026 analysis; the regulator's site returned 503 on every attempt, so no eSafety document was read directly. 2 The Molly Rose Foundation's April 2026 briefing, PDF downloaded and read, reporting a Youthinsight poll of 1,050 twelve- to fifteen-year-olds fielded 12–31 March 2026; the parent figure is the regulator's, read through Tech Policy Press; the British split via Flew. 3 Bilston et al., *JAMA Network Open*, 3 August 2026, 9(8):e2631107, read at source including the declared advisory-group role; the Korean shutdown evaluations as cited in the briefing at note 2, not read at source; Terry Flew, University of Sydney, 21 July 2026. 4 The Ministry of Digital Development and Information's reply of 8 September 2026, read at source.

THE MACRO DESK • NINE OF THE ELEVEN WERE REAL

The ten-year rose eleven basis points last week. Nine of them were real yield and two were inflation. That distinction decides whether bonds help you

A payroll print of twenty-nine thousand should have rallied the long end. It sold off instead — because the market is not pricing the Fed, it is charging rent.

AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE	LEVEL	WEEK
VWRA	\$192.74	▼ 0.40%
Global agg (AGGU)	\$5.725	▼ 0.12%
US 2-year	4.46%	▼ 4bp
US 10-year	5.28%	▲ 11bp
DXV	101.93	▲ 0.95%
USD/SGD	1.2789	flat
Brent	\$102.25	▼ 1.98%
Gold	\$4,140.19	▼ 3.7%
Bitcoin (live, Sun 05:33)	\$84,684	▲ 0.68%

Equities and bonds at Friday 2 October's close; bitcoin live this morning, because it never closed. Market explanation, not advice.¹

Three weeks ago the Federal Reserve raised rates, unanimously, twelve to nothing — into headline inflation of 3.4 per cent, of which gasoline is up 27.4 per cent and fuel oil 52.0 year on year, while core sits a point lower at 2.4. A supply shock, fought with a demand tool. On 1 October the long end broke in four currencies at once: the US ten-year touched 5.34 per cent, its highest since 2002; thirty-year gilts passed 6 per cent for the first time since 1998; the French ten-year hit a twenty-five-year high. No central bank did anything that day.²

Then Friday's payrolls: +29,000 against a forecast near 90,000, July and August revised down a net 60,000 with July turning negative, unemployment 4.2, wage growth 3.0 per cent, the slowest in five years. Equities read it as good news and closed up 0.73. The long end sold off anyway.³

140bp

BY WHICH THE TEN-YEAR NOTE NOW OUT-YIELDS THE RATE THE FED ACTUALLY SETS — 5.28 AGAINST AN EFFECTIVE 3.88 — THREE WEEKS AFTER A HIKE. 2S10S HAS GONE 46 TO 82 BASIS POINTS SINCE THURSDAY WEEK¹

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD AND BITCOIN

The decomposition is the whole desk. Of the ten-year's eleven basis points the real yield supplied nine and the breakeven two — and that breakeven, 2.36 per cent, is the identical figure printed a week ago against actual headline inflation of 3.4. The bond market is not arguing about inflation; it is demanding more to lend long. Term premium, not expectations — and a term-premium selloff does not reverse when the Fed does what the market expects. VWRA is 4.7 per cent off its high and refusing to break.¹

THE SCEPTIC • THE TRAP IS SYMMETRICAL

The honest contrarian is not a bond bull but a question about the hike. Set the Committee's own words — “economic activity is expanding at a solid pace” — against a three-month payroll average of 50,700 and a July revised to minus ten thousand.⁴

ON THE CALENDAR

Wednesday 7 October — September FOMC minutes, a date this desk *derived* rather than read: the Fed lists it as to be determined, but every 2026 release has landed twenty-one days after the meeting. 14 October — US September CPI, confirmed. 27–28 October — FOMC. Singapore's policy statement and third-quarter flash: contested — last year's landed on 14 October, one dated note says the final week; the statistics office refused us and the central bank's pages render empty. Both, rather than a guess.⁵

Asia decoupled. The Nikkei rose 2.93 per cent to 68,309 while the yen barely moved at 157.83. Korea's September exports hit \$120.9bn, up 83.5 per cent, semiconductors \$60.3bn — the impulse behind Singapore's 52.9 electronics reading (p5). China, shut until Thursday, halted fuel exports for the month on 1 October, tightening diesel in the week the G7 was loosening it (p3).⁶

SOURCES 1 Treasury par and real yield curves as CSV from the Treasury's data centre, latest row 2 October 2026 (the HTML view mis-shifts columns and was not used); the New York Fed's reference-rate API; Yahoo chart series for VWRA, AGGU, the dollar index, Brent, gold and the Nikkei; CoinGecko for the live bitcoin level, cross-checked. 2 The Committee's 16 September statement; the Bureau of Labor Statistics' August price release; the Irish Times' 1 October account of the global selloff. 3 The Bureau's September employment release. 4 The analyst quoted in Al Jazeera's report of 2 October. 5 The Federal Reserve's 2026 calendar, which lists the minutes as to be determined; the Bureau's CPI schedule; the statistics office returned 403 and the central bank's pages render client-side. 6 Yahoo chart series; Korea Customs Service as reported; Trading Economics for the Chinese export halt.

THE RABBIT HOLE • SCALE MODEL KITS, ARMOUR AND AIRCRAFT

One database holds six hundred and ninety thousand kits. The single most-modelled object on earth is a Messerschmitt Bf 109, seven thousand and fifty-nine times

A box of grey plastic on branching frames, and a craft whose entire economy has been rearranged in eighteen months by a printer that resolves fourteen microns.

A plastic model kit is a box of grey polystyrene parts moulded onto sprues — the branching frames, also called runners — which you cut free, clean up, glue, paint, decal and weather into a static replica. Static: it does not move, does not run on rails, is not played with. It is a sculpture you assemble. The glue is not glue but solvent cement, which melts both surfaces and welds them; the standard bottle costs six US dollars and works by capillary action, run along a join you are already holding closed. A mainstream 1/35 armour kit runs three to eight hundred parts. Airfix's new 1/24 Messerschmitt has 405, and sells in Singapore for S\$330.¹

The gateway is almost always a rediscovery rather than a discovery. Here is one, in a modeller's own words on a forum this year: "When I was younger, around twelve to eighteen, I built some model kits, mostly tanks, with my cousin. I was never very good at it; I usually just glued everything together and painted it with a brush and whatever paint I had. It never looked good, and I was always jealous when I saw really fine models and wondered, 'How did they do that?'... Back then, the tanks we built had only one purpose: to be used in 'war' against each other."²

7,059

DATABASE RECORDS FOR THE MESSERSCHMITT BF 109, THE MOST-MODELLED SUBJECT ON EARTH — AHEAD OF GERMAN INFANTRY (6,773) AND THE SPITFIRE (6,122). THE SHERMAN HAS 4,156; THE TIGER I, 2,278³

THE SCALE OF THE WORLD, IN NUMBERS SOMEBODY ACTUALLY COUNTED

The hobby's database holds 1,206,439 records, of which 689,791 are kits: 254,912 static kits, 177,312 detail and conversion sets, 123,401 decal sheets, 61,385 figure sets. 333,927 are new tools rather than reboxes. And 3,375 are listed as "3D data file" deliveries rather than physical goods — the printing revolution, visible as a database field. One Japanese house alone accounts for 2,657 static kits, 537 tools and 580 catalogued paint colours. The single kit that defines the armour side, a 1/35 Tiger I, was new-tooled in 1989 and has been reboxed in thirteen separate years since; it still costs about fifty dollars.³

THE SCEPTIC • AND NOBODY KNOWS HOW BIG THE MARKET IS

Two market-research houses published figures in the same month, May 2026, that differ by sixty-seven per cent: one puts the plastic-kit market at \$4.7 billion in 2026 rising to \$8.5 billion by 2035; the other at \$2.82 billion rising to \$4.95. They cannot both be describing the same thing. Treat any market size you read about this hobby as a sales document, and prefer the counted numbers above, which at least have a method. The one thing both agree on — that adult hobbyists are the fastest-growing segment, as "digital detox trends intensify" — is also the thing neither measured.⁴

WHAT THE NEXT TWO PAGES DESCEND INTO

The community map — where the arguments happen, and what they are about. The gear, which is the heart of it: airbrushes from a hundred and twenty-five dollars to nearly eight hundred, the compressor you should buy cheap and the one you should not, the apartment ventilation problem that is not optional, paints, and the tool tier that did not exist five years ago. The custom tier, with real commission rates from the people who charge them — and two workshops in Singapore that will build to order. The cutting edge: the kit that cannot be completed without its 3D-printed parts, the pre-painted tank, and the fourteen-micron printer that caused all of it. Then the vocabulary, the economics, and the sceptic — which in this hobby has a name, and it is the shelf of doom.

SOURCES 1 Sprue Brothers' current listing for the standard solvent cement; Airfix's product copy for the 405-part count as carried by Hobby Bounties Singapore, with its Singapore price. Part-count ranges from the manufacturers' own kit listings. 2 A dated 2026 introduction thread on the KitMaker Network forums; the poster is pseudonymous and the words are his. 3 Scalemates' own faceted search counts, for every record figure, the subject rankings, the brand totals and the Tiger I tooling timeline; Large Scale Planes' own forum footer for the member, post and topic counts; the YouTube channels' own pages for subscriber counts. 4 MarkWide Research's plastic-model-kit market page and Verified Market Reports' model-kits page, both dated May 2026 and both read at source.

THE DEEP END • THE GEAR, AND WHERE IT ACTUALLY STOPS PAYING

The grail airbrush costs seven hundred and eighty-five pounds and is better than the two-hundred-and-twenty-nine-pound one below twelve psi, at very close range, on very thin paint

Buy the airbrush and the extraction. Buy the compressor cheap, on purpose — it is a motor and a tank, and it never touches your paint.

The airbrush is the buy-once decision and the ladder is short. At the UK distributor's published prices: Iwata Eclipse HP-CS £229, the default; HP-C Plus £295; and the grail, the Custom Micron CM-C Plus at £784.99. From Harder & Steenbeck's own shop: ULTRA US\$124.95, two moving parts fewer than anything else; Evolution Solo \$184.45; Infinity Solo \$243.95.¹

And the honest verdict on the grail, from the threads that ask it directly: the Micron's advantage appears below about twelve psi, at very close range, on very thin paint, and nowhere else. On a 1/35 tank at twenty psi it is a seven-hundred-and-eighty-five-pound Eclipse. The arguments people actually make for it are trigger feel and resale, which are real arguments and are not performance.²

US\$124

THE COMPRESSOR TO BUY — A CHINESE CLONE PISTON WITH A THREE-LITRE TANK, SOLD UNDER FIFTY NAMES. AGAINST A £699 STUDIO UNIT DELIVERING IDENTICAL AIR. A COMPRESSOR IS A MOTOR AND A TANK: NO PRECISION SURFACES, AND IT NEVER TOUCHES YOUR PAINT³

THE SCEPTIC • THE THING AN APARTMENT MAKES NON-OPTIONAL

The constraint is real: no garage, no balcony you would spray on in eighty-five per cent humidity, neighbours on three sides, and lacquer thinner is a respiratory hazard rather than a smell. Carbon filters capture particulate overspray. They do not capture solvent vapour for long. The compact Japanese desk booth, about US\$169, draws honest complaints: its filter "gets clogged quickly" on surfacer, and "after airbrushing there's still a small amount of thinner smell." The only arrangement that works in a flat is ducting the booth out of a window and wearing a half-mask with organic-vapour cartridges.⁴

PAINTS, AND THE PRICING FACT THAT EXPLAINS A WHOLE SHIFT

The quality standard is Japanese lacquer: 10ml at US\$2.99, with its levelling thinner at \$6.49 for 110ml — the hobby's most-recommended consumable, because it retards drying just enough to let a lacquer flow out glass-smooth. Tamiya's minis are \$2.90, and the dominant practice, perverse to outsiders, is to thin the acrylic with the lacquer thinner. Then the Australian pre-thinned lacquer taking share: 30ml for US\$3.89.⁵

THE TOOLS, AND THE BRAND THAT TOOK THE PREMIUM TIER

The famous object is the God Hand Ultimate Nipper at about US\$52 — a single ultra-thin guillotine blade whose maker claims it needs "two kilograms or less of force to cut 3mm plastic, compared with 3.5 to 10 for general nippers," which is what stops the plastic whitening. Every retailer repeats the warning: these are finishing nippers, not cutters, and they break on thick gates, resin or photo-etch. Buy a cheap second pair for the rough cut. Around it a Chinese premium tier has appeared that did not exist five years ago: single-blade cutters at \$36 to \$60, an electric reciprocating sander at \$89.95, and a wash-free airbrush at \$45.95 with sealed paint bottles and no internal paint path, so there is nothing to clean. A veteran reviewer's note: "Chinese grits do not match up with US or other western ones." And why the tier exists: "the kits are more complex and more expensive... needing better tools to build them."⁶

SOURCES 1 The Airbrush Company's UK price list, inclusive of VAT, for every Iwata figure including the nozzle base; Harder & Steenbeck's shop for its range and parts. 2 Three long-running FineScale Modeler threads asking the comparison directly, read at source. 3 Hobbyist Haven and Sprue Brothers for the clone-tier and branded compressor prices; the argument is ours, and the one the community's money-saving threads make. 4 Community reports on both booths, read at source; the ducting and respirator conclusion follows from what carbon filters do and do not capture. 5 Sprue Brothers for all paint and thinner prices; the Australian maker's account and a user in a KitMaker thread. 6 Gap Games and Sprue Brothers for the nipper prices and the maker's force claim; Hobbyist Haven for the Chinese tier; Hyperscale's dated four-tool review for both quotations.

THE DEEP END • THE STATE OF THE ART, AND THE SHELF OF DOOM

A printer that resolves fourteen microns has produced the first mainstream kit that cannot be finished without its printed parts

A 1/35 rivet is fifteen to thirty microns across. Injection tooling cannot cut an undercut; a printer does not care. That one fact has rearranged the whole aftermarket.

The landmark of the year is a Mustang. Reviewed on 30 August, a 1/32 P-51B at US\$165 arrives with suspiciously few plastic sprues — by design. Only the large structural parts are moulded in grey styrene; the cockpit and gear bays are 3D printed, “achieving a level of detail traditional injection moulding can’t match,” printed as single integrated assemblies. The reviewer’s emphasis is the point: “the included 3D-printed resin parts are essential to the kit, not optional extras... The model cannot be completed without them.” The plain boxing is US\$129.99, so this is at the normal price point already. The question nobody has answered: what you do when you need a replacement printed part in five years.¹

The enabling number is fourteen micrometres. The current large resin printer resolves 14 by 19 microns in XY at 0.02mm in Z, for US\$563; the ladder runs down to \$195. A 1/35 rivet is fifteen to thirty microns across. That is the whole explanation for why printed detail now beats injection moulding, and why two one-man brands in New Zealand and Britain announced complete 1/32 aircraft this year. The honest cost in a Singapore flat: uncured photopolymer is a sensitiser, and you need isopropyl washing, a UV cure station and ventilation — the extraction problem from the last page, twice. The \$158 air purifier is not optional.²

\$50–67

THE PRICE OF A SET OF WHITE-METAL INDIVIDUAL-LINK TRACKS FOR A US\$55 TANK. A WORKING COMMISSION BUILDER’S VERDICT ON THE WHOLE AFTERMARKET: “LIKE ADDING RED DOTS AND LASERS TO PISTOLS. THEY GENERALLY DON’T MAKE YOU BETTER, JUST POORER”³

THE SCEPTIC • THE SHELF OF DOOM, AND THE COMMISSION THAT PAYS LESS THAN FAST FOOD

The hobby has named its own money pit. The stash — unbuilt kits — becomes the shelf of doom, and the diagnosis is advanced modeller’s syndrome: buying aftermarket a kit does not need. From a build log: “the PE and 3D gear cost WAY more than the kit itself.” On the custom tier the honesty is bracing. Real rates from the people charging them: “I charge about two times what the kit and supplies cost me”; one job at \$375 against \$60 of materials; a benchmark of \$1,000 minimum for an average 1/35 model at fifty-plus hours. Then the sum that ends it: “If you spend forty hours building a largely out-of-the-box kit and charge \$400, you’re making less money per hour than the kid flipping burgers in your local fast-food joint.” Another, flatly: for most, “commission work is an express highway to despair and pain.” In Singapore the route exists and is unpriced: two workshops, one in Toa Payoh listing the armed forces and museums among its clients, one on Bencoolen Street. A phone call and a quote, not a web checkout.⁴

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS, AT REAL PRICES

Lurk for a fortnight first. Then: a Tamiya 1/35 kit at about US\$50; the Eclipse at £229 or the ULTRA at \$125, not the Micron; a clone compressor, about \$120; a booth you will duct out of a window plus a half-mask, S\$150–450; paint and thinner, about \$40; Extra Thin at \$6; cheap nippers for gates and one good single-blade; sanding sticks at \$3.59 for two; a glass-lens magnifier at \$69.99. Roughly S\$800 to S\$1,200 all in — and it is the last airbrush you buy.

NEXT DESCENTS — YOU PICK TOMORROW’S HOBBY

SDR & signal hunting — software-defined receivers, waterfall displays and decoding what nobody meant you to hear.

Stained glass & leaded panels — copper foil against lead came, a flat cold craft with its own toolset and a century-old argument.

Bookbinding & book repair — Coptic to case binding, bone folders and linen thread, and an archival-materials rabbit hole underneath.

SOURCES 1 Gary Wickham’s review for The Modelling News, 30–31 August 2026, quoted verbatim; Sprue Brothers for both prices. 2 Elegoo’s own store and announcement pages; two one-man-brand announcements from The Modelling News, December 2025 and January 2026. Competing printers’ 2026 prices were not read. 3 Sprue Brothers’ track prices; the quotation from a dated Armorama thread. 4 Live KitMaker and FineScale threads, quoted verbatim; two dated commission threads, rates quoted verbatim; the Singapore workshops from their own listings, which publish no prices.

FITNESS · THE NUMBER IS NOT THE NUMBER

Low fitness was the single biggest risk of death in 580,290 people. It still accounted for fewer deaths than blood pressure — and it was never measured as VO2 max

Risk to you and deaths in a country are different questions. Most of the longevity conversation answers the second with the first one's number.

A prospective cohort of 580,290 US veterans referred for maximal treadmill testing, mean follow-up 10.2 years, published on 4 September. Fully adjusted, low cardiorespiratory fitness carried a relative risk of death of 1.77 (1.75–1.79) — the largest single factor examined, ahead of hypertension at 1.33. Then the order reverses. By population attributable risk, hypertension accounts for 21.8 per cent (15.2–28.0) of deaths and low fitness for 14.7 per cent (8.1–21.1), because far more people have high blood pressure.¹

Note that definition, because it is the second half of this page. The lowest quintile is a treadmill workload, not a gas-exchange measurement. Attributable risk is also a modelling quantity: it assumes the relation is causal and the exposure removable, and demonstrates neither. The cohort is mostly male veterans referred for clinical exercise testing — selected and symptomatic.¹

234×

MORE PARTICIPANTS IN THE CARDIORESPIRATORY-FITNESS LITERATURE THAN IN THE MEASURED-VO2-MAX LITERATURE, BY ONE CARDIOLOGIST'S READING OF A 2024 META-ANALYSIS. OVER 99 PER CENT OF THE OUTCOME EVIDENCE IS TREADMILL METS²

THE SCEPTIC · "THE FLAWED VO2 MAX CRAZE"

A cardiologist's February essay makes the argument this study walks into. Essentially all the longevity outcome data — the veterans cohorts, the 122,007-patient clinic cohort — comes from METs on a treadmill, not from measured VO2 max with a metabolic cart. The directly-measured dataset he points to is a Finnish cohort of 1,294 men from 2001. Each one-MET improvement tracks a 14 to 15 per cent mortality reduction; smartwatch VO2-max estimates carry 7 to 16 per cent error and "consistently underestimate in fit people." His conclusion is practical: use METs-based functional capacity — free, validated, and with the outcomes behind it. *General guidance, not medical advice.*²

THE CHATTER · THREE ARGUMENTS THE LONGEVITY WORLD IS HAVING

Zone two is being argued down. A Singapore family physician, writing in May and citing a 2025 review, argues that when total work is matched, higher intensity matches or beats zone two for mitochondrial adaptation — zone two's apparent edge often just reflecting more hours. He puts the Norwegian four-by-four at roughly 7 to 9 per cent VO2 max in eight weeks.³

THREE THINGS TO TRY, WITH THEIR PUBLISHED PRESCRIPTIONS

Split the squats across the day. An eight-week trial, 45 trained young men, back squat three days a week: one arm did three sets of twenty in a session, the other one set of twenty, three times a day — the same sixty reps. One-rep max rose +20.59kg fragmented against +28.93kg traditional, with no significant difference between groups on any outcome, and the fragmented arm enjoyed it more. *Eighteen- to twenty-five-year-old men, one exercise.*⁴

Put the bike after the barbell, and know the trade. 108 women aged 40 to 77, twelve supervised weeks: cycling added after identical resistance work gave -2.04 points of body fat (-2.94 to -1.14) and +4.53 ml/kg/min of estimated VO2 max, and cost 6.68kg of leg-press one-rep max. And stop optimising the clock: 93 older adults trained at their personal peak against their trough time of day, and mid-thigh pull came out at 0.06 N/kg (-0.76 to 0.88). Train when you will turn up.⁵

SOURCES 1 Myers, Kokkinos et al., "Cardiorespiratory Fitness and Population Attributable Risk: The ETHOS Study," *European Journal of Preventive Cardiology*, online 4 September 2026; the complete abstract read verbatim through the public biomedical index, the journal being paywalled. 2 Eric Topol, "The flawed VO2 max craze," 23 February 2026, read at source; a second analyst's February piece for the confounding point. 3 A Singapore physician's May 2026 post, read at source, citing a 2025 review not read here; NBC News, 3 February 2026. 4 Zhai et al., *Journal of Exercise Science and Fitness* 2026;24(4):200521, full text read through the European public archive. 5 Bagheri et al., *JISSN* 2026, and Bruggisser et al., *Journal of Cachexia, Sarcopenia and Muscle* 2026;17(5):e70390, abstracts read verbatim through the public index.

DEPARTURES • THE WEEK THE BOOKINGS OPENED

Japan's weather agency has stopped looking at its mountains. A century of first-snow records ends, and this season's dates cannot be compared with any before them

Also: Europe's travel authorisation still has no start date and now costs nearly three times what it did, and Nagano's monkey bus no longer takes cash.

The first hatsukansetsu of the season — first snow seen on a mountain — was logged at Mt Asahidake in Hokkaido on 2 October, and it is the last one that will mean what the previous ones meant. From this season the meteorological agency has ended the practice of staff visually observing forty-four mountains, switching to analysed snow-depth data from automated stations, radar and satellite — which detects snow through cloud and at night. The agency says plainly that this season's dates cannot be directly compared with previous records. A better instrument has ended a century-long series.¹

And a held thread closes, badly. This desk has carried “ETIAS, Q4 2026” unverified for weeks. Read at the European Commission's own page, the scheme “is currently not in operation... The European Union will inform about the specific date... several months prior to its launch.” There is no Q4 2026 at the EU source; that figure is not the EU's. What the EU has published is a price: the fee is now €20, up from €7, justified by inflation since 2018, in a two-month parliamentary review and effective the day the system goes live.²

€20

THE NEW EUROPEAN TRAVEL-AUTHORISATION FEE, NEARLY THREE TIMES THE OLD €7 — SET FOR A SYSTEM WITH NO ANNOUNCED START DATE, COVERING THIRTY COUNTRIES AND STAYS TO NINETY DAYS IN ANY ONE HUNDRED AND EIGHTY²

THE CHATTER • HAKUBA'S OWN NUMBERS, AND THE BUS FARE THAT TELLS THE REST

The town's tourism department recorded 2.71 million visitors in 2024, a level last seen twenty years earlier; in the November-to-February peak about 1.3 million came, up 14 per cent, with more than 890,000 on the slopes, 46 per cent of them from overseas. Land prices rose 30 per cent to September 2024, the fourth steepest in Japan. A slope food truck was charging ¥2,500 for a beef bowl, and the Nagano-Hakuba bus that cost ¥1,800 five years ago now goes for ¥3,800 — more than a seat to Tokyo Disneyland, two hundred and fifty kilometres away.³

THE SCEPTIC • A HOTEL OPENING THAT IS A HOTEL REOPENING

THE ALPS HOTEL HAKUBA takes its grand opening on 15 December and the trade is calling it a new luxury property. The hotel's own site says otherwise: “due to a change in hotel management, our property will undergo extensive renovation works from 1 April 2026 through November 2026,” closed throughout. A rebrand and a refit — and it is at Hakuba Norikura in Otari, not Happo. It also posted, on 22 September, a notice of unauthorised access to its booking system.⁴

IN BRIEF

Singapore Airlines is pre-announcing a cabin. Its 29 September release puts more than a hundred new dishes and serveware made with Christofle into Suites, First and Business from November — and calls it “one pillar” of a programme covering next-generation cabin products and a new entertainment system, to be “unveiled in Singapore in November 2026.” A reveal flagged six weeks out.⁵

A Nagano ski field will not open at all. Kaida Kogen Mia, in Kiso, announced on 1 October that it will not operate this season, citing “various circumstances.” Also gone: Gokase Highland in Miyazaki, Japan's most southerly ski area, permanently closed this summer. The season's first lift anywhere is Yeti in Shizuoka around 23 October; Nagano's first is Karuizawa Prince on 31 October, on artificial snow.⁶

SOURCES 1 SnowJapan's report of the Japan Meteorological Agency's change of method and the Asahidake observation of 2 October 2026. 2 The European Commission's migration and home-affairs page: operating status, the absence of a date, the €20 fee and the review period. The EU's consumer site returned a server error. 3 Nippon.com's dated feature of 26 May 2025, citing Hakuba town's tourism department. 4 The hotel's English site, including both notices; Banyan Tree's Japan property page. 5 Singapore Airlines' newsroom, 29 September 2026. 6 SnowJapan's not-operating list, updated 2 October, and its early-openings tracker.

DEPARTURES • THE SMALL PRINT THAT MOVES

The bus to the snow monkeys now runs every twenty minutes and will not take your money at the door

From December the ticket must be bought online, days ahead, as a combined fare-and-admission set. The park is also raising its gate price, and has not said to what.

Nagaden Bus published its winter timetable on 4 September, and it is a different system. From 5 December to 5 April, direct buses run Nagano Station East Exit to the Snow Monkey Park every twenty to thirty minutes — a better headway than before. But the Shiga Kogen express no longer calls at the park at all; monkey traffic moves to a new dedicated line. Services are capacity-controlled: you board in queue order at Bay 24, and if it is full you wait. Tickets must be bought in advance online as the combined bus-and-admission set, on sale since 5 September. There is no on-board payment and no convenience-store sale, and same-day station sales may stop once the web cap is reached.¹

The park itself has gone the same way: online tickets launched on 6 August, and from December to April online holders get entry priority. An admission revision takes effect on 1 December — the park posted the notice on 20 September and the new amount does not appear in readable text anywhere on its site. Current admission is ¥800. We are not guessing at the new one.²

¥8,200

THE COMPANION DAY RATE AT HAKUBA'S HAPPO-ONE FOR SEASON-PASS HOLDERS, FROM ¥8,700. PASSES WENT ON SALE AT TEN O'CLOCK ON 1 OCTOBER; THE EARLY-BIRD WINDOW RUNS TO 15 NOVEMBER, IS CREDIT-CARD ONLY, AND "CANNOT BE CANCELLED OR REFUNDED FOR ANY REASON"³

THE CHATTER • SIX MILES A DOLLAR, AND A DATE TO DIARISE

The flag carrier's lifestyle app turns six this month and is paying eight miles per Singapore dollar at more than sixty-five local partners through October, with half-price dining vouchers released at noon on the 2nd, 9th, 16th and 23rd. A mall-loyalty tie-up now lets a linked account earn both currencies on one spend, and the app's miles convert one-for-one into the airline programme within twenty-one days. It is the most concrete points move of the quarter for a Singapore household, and it is a calendar item rather than a strategy: the vouchers are released at a fixed time on a fixed day and are gone.⁴

THE SCEPTIC • THE PASS THAT IS NOT A DISCOUNT

Nagaden sells a Snow Monkey Pass for Bus at ¥6,800 in winter and ¥4,800 in summer, covering the return express plus admission. Price it at the published rates: the express is ¥2,000 each way and admission is ¥800. The summer version is exactly break-even; the winter version costs about two thousand yen more per adult than paying separately. It is not a saving — it is a reserved seat under the new capacity rules, which may well be worth it, but should be bought knowing that.⁵

ALSO WORTH A LINE

A dark-sky attraction that is dark. Star Village Achi's published operating calendar runs 11 April 2026 to 22 March 2027 with exclusion periods including 24 September to 9 October. Anyone booking off a guidebook in the first week of October arrives at a closed gondola.⁶

Scoot refused us. Every request to the carrier's own site returned 403 this session, so its Guiyang and Naha route claims — both already covered here — were not re-verified at the airline's page and are not restated. Changi's newsroom renders only through JavaScript and produced nothing in the window; we are not manufacturing a terminal item to fill the slot.⁷

SOURCES 1 Nagaden Bus's 2026–27 winter timetable notice, published 4 September 2026: headway, the line change, capacity control, the advance-sale rule and the absence of on-board and convenience-store sales. 2 Jigokudani Yaen-koen's site: the online-ticket launch of 6 August 2026, the December-to-April priority, and the 20 September notice of an admission revision effective 1 December, whose amount is not published in readable text. 3 Happon-one's notice of 5 September 2026 for the sale time, windows, payment restriction, no-refund clause and the companion rate. 4 Singapore Airlines' own newsroom release on the app's sixth anniversary. 5 Nagaden Bus's and Nagano Dentetsu's ticket pages, including the quoted refund clause, the vending-machine-only rule and the published sales periods; the comparison is our arithmetic at the operators' published fares. 6 Star Village Achi's operating calendar. 7 Observed directly this session.

THE GRAND TOUR • NAGANO PREFECTURE

Nozawa has averaged sixty-four per cent more snow than Hakuba over fourteen seasons. Last winter it had more than double

October is not when you go to Nagano. It is when the decision closes — and almost every number that decides it was published in the last five weeks.

Start with the thing the brochures will not tell you, because it is computable. One snow service has logged observed snowfall at the same base areas every day for fourteen seasons. Our arithmetic from its published totals: the fourteen-season mean is Hakuba 486cm, Shiga Kogen 754cm, Nozawa Onsen 796cm — Nozawa averaging sixty-four per cent more snow than Hakuba. Last season was starker: 733cm against 339. And Hakuba's own range runs 223cm to 782cm, a three-and-a-half-fold spread, with last winter the second-worst in the record.¹

The season, at the resorts' own dates. Nozawa has published its whole window: 28 November to 5 May, with full operation and full pricing 19 December to 28 March. That middle band is the honest reliable season. Hakuba Valley has published no 2026–27 opening date at all — its ticket page says only that the all-mountain pass goes on sale “around November.” Nozawa's day lift is ¥7,800 against Hakuba Valley's ¥11,100: at Friday's cross, S\$63 against S\$90.²

7/2/4

TIMES THE MONKEY TROOP WAS LATE, LEFT EARLY, AND FAILED TO APPEAR AT ALL BETWEEN 1 AND 20 SEPTEMBER, BY THE PARK'S OWN PUBLISHED ATTENDANCE REGISTER. AUTUMN IS ITS WORST SEASON: MOUNTAIN FOOD PEAKS, AND THE RUT RUNS FROM SEPTEMBER³

THE SCEPTIC • THE PARK SAYS IT, SO WE WILL

Jigokudani Yaen-koen's own hours page carries the sentence every photograph suppresses: “The monkeys bathing in the hot spring is only one way of coping with the harsh winter cold. They are not in the hot spring 24 hours a day, all year round.” It also states that this is a feeding facility, not a zoo, and that “there are days when the monkeys do not appear in the park at all.” Its own weekly forecast of 27 September names autumn as the worst window: mountain food peaks from late September and the rut from late October. A normal day runs arrival 09:00 to 10:00, departure 15:30 to 16:30.³

THE PASS ARITHMETIC — SHOW THE WORKING

The national rail pass does not pay for this trip. It is ¥53,000 for seven days; Tokyo–Nagano return is about ¥16,000, so you need three and a third of those round trips elsewhere before it breaks even. Worse, no national pass covers the legs that matter — the Nagano Dentetsu line, the Nagaden bus to the park and the Alpico bus to Hakuba are all non-JR. The Snow Monkey Pass, ¥4,800, covers a day's unlimited Nagano Dentetsu rail including the limited-express surcharge, the local bus and admission, against about ¥4,120 à la carte before the surcharge and bus.⁴

GETTING THERE, IN THREE LEGS

Tokyo is the only gateway — there is no commercial Singapore service to Komatsu, Toyama or Matsumoto. From Tokyo the Hokuriku Shinkansen is eighty to a hundred minutes, about ¥8,000, several trains an hour; the park's own access page gives the fastest as seventy-nine minutes. *The fare could not be confirmed at the railway's own site, which blocks us outright.* Then Nagano to Hakuba on the Alpico express: one hour ten minutes, ¥2,900 on the summer tariff, seven departures a day — the winter fare is unpublished and one feature reports ¥3,800. The underrated fact: the Nagano Dentetsu terminus is underground beneath JR Nagano Station, so monkeys, Obuse and Yudanaka all start in the same building as the bullet train.⁵

SOURCES 1 Fourteen seasons of daily observed base-area snowfall as published by SnowJapan for all three resorts; the means, ratios and range are our arithmetic from those totals, not the service's figures. Base elevations from the same pages. 2 Nozawa Onsen's lift-ticket page; Hakuba Valley's ticket page, which gives no opening date; both day rates converted at Friday's reference rate. 3 Jigokudani Yaen-koen's guide page and its weekly attendance forecast of 27 September 2026. 4 The national pass tariff from 1 October; Nagano Dentetsu's and Nagaden Bus's ticket pages; the comparison is our arithmetic at published fares. 5 Japan-guide and the park's access page; Alpico's timetable and fare table; the ¥3,800 from the feature cited on p19. JR East returned 403 to every request.

THE GRAND TOUR • WHERE TO SLEEP, AND WHAT IT COSTS

Base in Shibu if you want the village and Yudanaka only if you want the platform. The community ratings separate them by four-tenths of a point

A thirteen-hundred-year-old stone lane you walk in wooden sandals, against a station town. One of them is also dug up until December.

Nagano city is a hub, not a destination — rated 3.5 by eight hundred users on the main English travel reference, which is the score of a place you use. Shibu Onsen rates 4.0 against Yudanaka’s 3.6, and the difference is the whole choice: Shibu is the stone-paved lane with nine public baths that you walk in *yukata* and *geta*; Yudanaka is where the train stops. One live warning, from the inn that is the reason people photograph Shibu: stone-paving works restrict vehicle access into the village from 29 June until early December. That four-storey early-Shōwa timber inn is a registered cultural property with eight free-flowing baths in-house, and takes bookings only through third-party platforms.¹

In Hakuba the villages are not interchangeable. Happo is the transport heart, seventy minutes from Nagano, and the steep mountain — the default for a competent skier with a twelve-year-old. Wadano is the wooded hillside above it, walkable to the gondola, quieter and dearer. Echoland is the flat restaurant-and-bar strip: cheapest food, furthest from a lift. Tsugaike, Norikura and Cortina at the north end are ¥3,200 and an hour forty from Nagano — the most snow and the fewest options off the hill. And Nozawa Onsen is a single village you can walk end to end, with thirteen free public bathhouses and the ski field rising out of it. If you are not splitting days across ten resorts, it is the better village and the cheaper lift.²

\$6.49

THE MONKEY PARK’S CURRENT ADMISSION AT FRIDAY’S CROSS. ALSO: A NOZAWA DAY LIFT \$63, A HAKUBA VALLEY DAY LIFT \$90, THE SNOW MONKEY PASS \$39, THE NATIONAL RAIL PASS \$430³

WHAT THE FORUMS ACTUALLY SAY — AND THE YEN, WHICH IS THE QUIET PART

Two consistent reads, both from community rating pools rather than our own measurement. The first is the Shibu-over-Yudanaka split above. The second is Kamikōchi, rated 4.4 by 279 users and sixty-seventh of two hundred and nine most-visited places in Japan, with the standing warning that it “gets very busy during the summer holidays and on weekends during the autumn leaf season” — which is now. It is a car-free valley year-round: you park at Sawando for ¥800 a day or Akandana for ¥600 and take the shuttle, and the road is open 17 April to 15 November only. On money, the honest line is not the one people want. The yen has gone almost nowhere all year. Against the Singapore dollar it opened 2026 at 121.87, ranged 120.97 to 126.90, and sits at 123.20 — up 1.1 per cent, a band under five per cent wide. It is not getting cheaper; it is *staying* cheap. Budget at about a hundred and twenty-three and stop waiting for a better entry (p14).³

THE SCEPTIC • THE PREMIUM TIER WILL NOT QUOTE YOU A PRICE

Three of the four properties worth naming at the top of this market publish no rate at all. The Hoshino group’s KAI Alps at Omachi Onsen — forty-eight rooms, two onsen, hearths, fifteen minutes from the station, and verified on the group’s own property list — carries this in the group’s own English words: “Bookings will only be accepted from within Japan. For further information, please check the Japanese website pages.” No English rate exists. The new Hakuba hotel on p19 publishes none either, and has a security notice on its door. The ryokan at the monkey-park trailhead, open since 1929 and claiming the largest volume of free-flowing hot-spring water in the prefecture, quotes only by plan. What is priced, and priced well, is the mainstream: the valley’s largest hotel at Cortina runs 253 rooms, ski-in and ski-out with its own onsen. The honest call: one or two nights of ryokan and *kaiseki*, then a hotel at the ski base — where what you want is a drying room, a lift at the door and breakfast at half past seven, not nine courses at six.⁴

SOURCES 1 Japan-guide’s user rating pools for Nagano city, Shibu Onsen and Yudanaka Onsen, read 3 October 2026; the Shibu inn’s own front page for the cultural-property status, the eight baths, the booking channels and the stone-paving access restriction. 2 Alpico’s own timetable and fare table for the village stops and journey times; Hakuba Valley’s own resort pages; Nozawa Onsen’s own village and lift pages. 3 Conversions at the 2 October SGD/JPY reference rate of 123.20 and the operators’ published yen prices; the year’s range from the daily reference-rate series, the central bank’s own interface being in maintenance. Japan-guide for the Kamikōchi rating and seasonal warning; the official Kamikōchi site for the car ban, the two car parks and the 17 April to 15 November window, its 2026 event page rendering only through JavaScript. 4 Hoshino Resorts’ own property page for KAI Alps, including the quoted booking restriction; the Kanbayashi ryokan’s own site; Hakuba Valley’s own page for the Cortina hotel’s room count.

THE DIARY • THE DATED AGENDA

The race is five days away, the hospitality is gone, and the cheapest ticket on this page is twenty-eight dollars to watch Singapore play Paraguay

Every row below was re-checked against a venue, promoter or official seller. Two of our own standing entries were wrong and are corrected here.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW • PLAN AHEAD

- 9–11 OCT** ★ **Formula 1 Singapore Grand Prix**
MARINA BAY • THE FIRST SINGAPORE SPRINT WEEKEND. PADANG: FRI JJ LIN, SAT THE KILLERS, SUN LANA DEL REY AND JANET JACKSON. HOSPITALITY SOLD OUT BAR VISTA SUITE, FROM S\$7,508; ZONE 4 WALKABOUT FROM S\$198¹
- 10 OCT–8 NOV** **Deepavali Festival Village**
CAMPBELL LANE • THE HELD THREAD CLOSES, READ AT THE FESTIVAL'S OWN SITE. WORKSHOPS 17 AND 31 OCT³
- 17–18 OCT** ★ **BIGBANG — 〈XX : COSMOS〉**
CORRECTION: THE NATIONAL STADIUM, NOT THE INDOOR STADIUM. S\$158–498 • THE 17TH SOLD OUT IN TWO HOURS, FORCING THE 18TH⁴
- 29 OCT–15 NOV** **CATS**
SANDS THEATRE • S\$68–238, 145 MIN — DATES PER PROMOTER LISTINGS; THE VENUE'S OWN SITE 503'D ON EVERY PATH⁵
- 10–11 NOV** **My Chemical Romance**
INDOOR STADIUM • S\$128–408 • CORRECTION: NOT SOLD OUT — THE VENUE PAGE SAYS NOTHING OF THE KIND. RATED 13+²
- 13–17 NOV** ★ **Mizuho Blue Challenge football**
NATIONAL STADIUM • 13TH SINGAPORE V PARAGUAY FROM S\$28; 14TH JAPAN V BRAZIL FROM S\$98; 17TH A DOUBLE HEADER ON ONE TICKET. VIP S\$888⁶
- 16–18 JAN** **Westlife 25**
INDOOR STADIUM • NOW THREE NIGHTS, NOT TWO — THE 18TH WENT ON SALE 21 SEP. S\$138–328²

JAPAN & THE REGION

THE ONES WITH A TICKET CLOCK

- 8–22 NOV** **Kyushu Basho — and it is gone**
FUKUOKA • THE ASSOCIATION'S OWN SELLER: "TICKETS ARE SOLD OUT ALL DATES. THERE WILL BE NO TICKETS SOLD ON THE DAY." ON-SALE WAS 19 SEPTEMBER⁷
- 14 NOV–28 MAR** ★ **Masterworks from the Musée d'Orsay**
TOKYO METROPOLITAN ART MUSEUM • ~110 WORKS • ¥2,400 ADULT, ¥2,200 ADVANCE, FREE UNDER 18 • CLOSED 22 DEC–3 JAN⁸
- 25 NOV–6 DEC** ★ **Rikugien autumn night viewing**
BUNKYO, TOKYO • 18:00–20:30 • ¥1,000 ADVANCE, ¥1,200 SAME DAY • NEW THIS YEAR, PROJECTION MAPPING ON THE STOREHOUSE. SALE DATE NOT YET ANNOUNCED⁹
- 28 NOV–5 MAY** **Nozawa Onsen opens**
NAGANO • FULL OPERATION 19 DEC–28 MAR; DAY LIFT ¥7,800. HAKUBA VALLEY HAS PUBLISHED NO DATE (P21)¹⁰
- 4–6 DEC** **Clockenflap**
CENTRAL HARBOURFRONT, HONG KONG • BLIND BIRD TICKETS ON SALE, LINE-UP NOT PUBLISHED; UNDER-16S NEED AN ADULT¹¹
- 4–11 FEB** ★ **Sapporo Snow Festival, 77th**
ODORI AND SUSUKINO • CONFIRMED ON THE JAPANESE PAGE; THE ENGLISH PAGE IS STALE AND STILL SHOWS 2025¹²

PLANNING NOTES • TWO CORRECTIONS, ONE LESSON, AND WHAT FAILED VERIFICATION

We had two things wrong and a reader should know which. BIGBANG is at the National Stadium, not the Indoor Stadium; and My Chemical Romance is not sold out — the venue's own page makes no such claim. Westlife has quietly become three nights. The lesson is the sumo: the on-sale was 19 September, four lottery rounds ran before it, and all fifteen days were gone before most people knew there was a date. The habit is not watching for the tournament; it is setting an alarm for the on-sale. For the twelve-year-old: Japan against Brazil at Kallang on 14 November from S\$98, or Singapore against Paraguay the night before at S\$28. The Orsay show admits under-18s free. Dropped for failing verification: Christmas Wonderland, whose own site still serves a 2025 closure page, for a third issue; the Marunouchi winter illuminations, where every circulating date is last season's; Moulin Rouge at the Sands, aggregator-only; and four promoter listings with no venue attached. And a correction of our own standing record: Post Malone is POSTPONED, not cancelled — announced 27 August by promoter, ticketer and venue together, no reason and no new date, refunds taking up to sixty business days. The whole Asia leg went with it.¹³

SOURCES 1 singaporegp.sg's own entertainment, tickets and race-schedule pages, read 3 October 2026. Session times are omitted: the day-by-day tabs did not extract reliably. 2 thekallang.com.sg's own event pages. 3 deepavali.sg, the festival organiser's own site. 4 The venue's own media release for the National Stadium and 17 October; the 18th corroborated at near-primary only. 5 Promoter listings; marinabaysands.com returned 503 on every path. 6 The venue's own event page and announcement release. 7 The sumo association's own ticketing site, quoted verbatim. 8 tobikan.jp's own exhibition pages. 9 The Tokyo Metropolitan Park Association's own notice of 3 September 2026. 10 Nozawa Onsen's own lift-ticket page. 11 clockenflap.com. 12 snowfes.com, Japanese pages. 13 Each dropped item checked against the promoter, venue or organiser named; the postponement announced jointly on 27 August 2026 and reported by three outlets.

THE TABLE • FOUR ROOMS, NO VERDICTS

Four genuinely new places opened in Singapore this fortnight, and not one has been reviewed by anybody who paid for their own meal

The category's bottleneck is no longer supply. It is verification — and this month's listicles are recycling a pizzeria that opened sixteen months ago.

Ojeje is a tonkatsu-and-udon specialist from Jeju, and this is its first outlet anywhere outside Korea — Raffles City basement, straight out of City Hall station. Founded in 2020 by owner-chef Kim Ji-hoon, it has grown to six directly-operated restaurants in Seoul, which is a different proposition from a franchise sold abroad. Two technical signatures: the pork is wet-aged before frying, and the udon is made on site daily in dedicated noodle rooms.¹

Jomaru brought gamjatang — Korean pork-bone soup — to Tanjong Pagar Road in late September, from a chain with more than two hundred and twenty outlets. The format is communal: the cauldron from S\$56.80, braised pork bone in soy, spicy or “Volcano,” potato-cheese pancake. The tell is at the other end of the menu, haejangguk at S\$21.80 — the single-serve hangover soup — and a kitchen that runs until two in the morning. That is a positioning statement about that street. One dated source only; we looked for a second and found none.²

Little Rituals opened on 29 September — the firmest date here — inside a clothes shop on Arab Street, the third venue from the team behind two existing matcha rooms. The technical difference is cold-whisking rather than hot, which one reviewer found gave “a thicker, creamier texture with less of the usual graininess.” Flavoured matcha from S\$5.50 petite, S\$10.50 regular, with ceremonial grade and koicha for the purists. Not halal-certified, worth printing given the address. It shuts at five on weekdays: a café rationing itself.³

THE BUZZ • FOUR OPENINGS, FOUR VERDICTS OF NOT YET

Ojeje has exactly one published opinion and the writer declares it a hosted tasting. Jomaru has one dated visit whose most concrete finding is that every table was occupied on a weekday evening — which is anticipation, not a verdict on the broth. Little Rituals has a texture note four days old. Yerba Yerba, on Bali Lane, has a Senior Minister's social-media post about yerba mate and an embassy promoting it locally, and not one word yet about whether the mate is any good. Nobody has been back twice. Nobody has paid their own way and said so.⁴

THE SCEPTIC • THE PRESS CYCLE HAS OUTRUN THE KITCHENS

The problem this month is not that the cooking is bad; it is that nobody can yet tell you, and the listicles have stopped waiting to find out. One guide's “ten new restaurants and cafés in October” opens with a pizzeria that has been serving on Mohamed Sultan Road since 17 May 2025 — sixteen months — because it has launched a buffet. Another's five-restaurant list contains a July opening and four names this magazine has already run. Of the eleven venues across both, three stood up as genuinely new and unrun.⁵

SEOUL IMPORT

FIRST OUTSIDE KOREA

WET-AGED TONKATSU

OPEN TILL 2AM

COLD-WHISKED MATCHA

CAFÉ INSIDE A SHOP

YERBA MATE

AFTERNOONS ONLY

NO BOOKINGS

NOT HALAL-CERTIFIED

TOO NEW TO CALL

THE HONESTY LEDGER

Not verified this issue: Ojeje's and Jomaru's exact opening days, neither published anywhere — both established only as “open by” a dated review. Yerba Yerba's date entirely; open by 1 October. Jomaru rests on a single source. Halal status is unstated for Jomaru and Yerba Yerba and we claim neither way. Two candidates were killed on date, and four more names were barred as already run here.⁶

SOURCES 1 Time Out Singapore's 17 September announcement, Eatbook's 1 October piece (which still listed prices as to be decided) and HungryGoWhere's first-hand visit of 2 October, which supplies the prices, hours and technique; the venue publishes no opening date. 2 HungryGoWhere's dated visit of 29 September 2026, the single source for this venue. 3 Eatbook's dated piece of 29 September 2026, including the cold-whisk texture note, prices, hours and the halal status. 4 As 1–3, plus Time Out's 1 October piece on the mate café; Instagram returned 429, SETHLUI 403, and Burpple, Reddit and Google reviews were unreachable. 5 Eatbook's October new-openings list and Time Out's five-restaurant list, both read 3 October, against the pizzeria's May 2025 launch coverage and the pasta counter's July dating in the same article. 6 This desk's verification record and the Table ledger.

THE UNDERCURRENT • HONG KONG

北上養老

Hong Kong has become the first rich jurisdiction to buy subsidised nursing-home beds inside another jurisdiction as a standing instrument of policy – and to pay its pensions, its medical vouchers and now its welfare cash across the border to meet them. It calls the arrangement choice. The queue it bypasses is twenty months long.

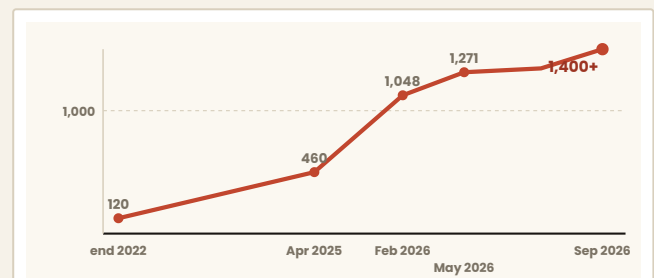
Bak-seung yeung-lou. Going north to grow old. The phrase is ordinary Cantonese and it now describes a machine. Under the Residential Care Services Scheme in Guangdong, Hong Kong’s Social Welfare Department signs contracts with care homes inside mainland China and pays them per occupied bed. The Hong Kong elder who takes one pays nothing – not for the room, the three meals, the twenty-four-hour nursing, the twice-weekly rehabilitation or the monthly doctor. At the end of 2022 there were 120 of them in two homes. By 16 September this year there were over 1,400, in twenty-nine homes, across all nine mainland cities of the Greater Bay Area.¹

Around that scheme a whole apparatus has been assembled, piece by piece, in under three years. Portable welfare payments. Old-age allowances payable across the boundary at HK\$1,675 and HK\$4,345 a month. An elderly health-care voucher pilot with twenty-one mainland service points, through which more than 40,600 Hong Kong elderly have made 101,000 claims worth about HK\$103 million. A cross-boundary health record. A two-way cross-boundary ambulance arrangement, operational since March.²

At the end of 2022 there were a hundred and twenty. There are now more than fourteen hundred, and the government will not say what it pays for a bed.

Set beside that the queue it is an alternative to. 19,196 people were on Hong Kong’s central waiting list for a subsidised residential place on 31 July, with a further 38,104 applications marked inactive.

The average wait for a subvented or contract home is twenty months. And a Guangdong home is not a separate programme a family applies to; it is listed as one of the options within “subsidised care-and-attention place.” There is no means test. If the mainland home you pick has a vacancy, you are matched directly. You have jumped twenty months.³



Twelve-fold in under four years. Hong Kong elders in subsidised Guangdong care homes. Meridian original, plotted from the government’s own published figures – a written reply, two departmental releases, a reply annex and the 2026 Policy Address.

“It is not suitable for the Government to disclose the relevant details.”

What does the bed cost? Hong Kong publishes, in its own budget estimates, exactly what a place at home costs it each month: HK\$18,809 in a subvented care-and-attention home, HK\$25,027 in a contract home, HK\$25,316 in a nursing home, HK\$16,025 in a bought private place. Asked in March by a legislator what it pays per place in the Guangdong homes and how that compares, the Secretary for Labour and Welfare declined. Fees “vary across the RCHes and concern the contract terms,” so “it is not suitable for the Government to disclose the relevant details” – adding only that “in overall terms, the Government pays a lower fee” than for a local place.⁴

SOURCES 1 The Social Welfare Department’s scheme materials and press releases of 17 December 2025 and 16 June 2026; the headcount series from a Legislative Council written reply of 21 May 2025, the department’s releases, a 25 March 2026 reply annex and the 2026 Policy Address, paragraph 393(iii), delivered 16 September 2026. The end-2022 figure of 120 is official data as reported. 2 The department’s allowance pamphlet of January 2026 for both rates; the Secretary for Health’s reply of 17 June 2026 for the voucher, health-record and ambulance figures; the department’s release of 17 December 2025 for the medical-subsidy ceilings and the appointed administrator; its release of 6 July 2026 for the remittance arrangement; the sixty-day residence rule from the scheme’s terms. 3 The department’s long-term-care statistics for July 2026; the scheme’s service brief and FAQ of 18 August 2026 for the absence of a means test and the matching process. 4 The 2026–27 Estimates, Head 170, for all four unit costs; the Secretary for Labour and Welfare’s reply of 25 March 2026.

The mechanism has a hinge in it, and the hinge is six months. From the day an elder is admitted to a Guangdong home, a trial period runs. During it, their central waiting-list application is marked inactive. Leave inside six months and the application is restored with its *original date*. Stay past six months and the long-term-care application ends. The scheme's own Chinese text is unambiguous about it. And the restoration right belongs only to elders referred from inside Hong Kong; those already living on the mainland who apply through an association's Shenzhen or Guangzhou offices get no retroactivity at all.¹

Note also who cannot go. Four categories are excluded by Hong Kong: elders under departmental guardianship, elders whose welfare payee is their own social worker, elders needing regular psychiatric follow-up, elders needing dialysis. The mainland adds its own: proof of freedom from infectious and psychiatric illness, and at least one family member, guarantor or guardian supporting the elder. Read the two lists together and the shape is plain. The frailest and the most alone are, by rule, the least exportable.¹

The frailest and the most alone are, by rule, the least exportable.

Now turn the arbitrage round. In the same years that Hong Kong began buying beds in Guangdong, its own homes were replacing local carers with imported ones. The departmental figures, tabled in July 2025: total care workers in elderly homes rose from 12,166 at the end of 2022 to 13,211 in March 2025 — but inside that total, local carers fell from 8,001 to 7,065 while imported carers rose from 4,165 to 6,146. The imported share went from 34.2 per cent to 46.5 per cent in twenty-seven months; local headcount fell 11.7 per cent. A special importation scheme opened in June 2023 and closed the older route to care-worker applications the same day. Labour moves south on a visa; residents move north

on a contract. Both legs of that are policy, and both are recent.²

This is not, on the evidence, a story about elders being pushed. The honest counter-case is strong and should be stated plainly. Fourteen hundred people in Guangdong sit against roughly 35,400 subsidised places inside Hong Kong and a waiting list of 19,196 — a rounding error. The flagship cash pilot for welfare recipients opened last October with a quota of 1,000; by early March the department had taken about 900 enquiries, sixteen applications, and approved ten. Legislators are complaining the mainland beds sit *empty*: of the twenty-six homes listed in March, eight had ten residents or fewer and two had none, while a single Shenzhen home held 208 of the 1,048, nearly a fifth. Voucher take-up in the bay area is about two per cent of the eligible Hong Kong elderly. The medical subsidy had 286 approvals and RMB1.4 million spent in four months.³

Asked about the needs of middle-class elders considering retirement on the mainland, the government said it had not conducted any relevant surveys. Nor had anyone else.

Two things complicate that comfortable reading. The first is that the government has done no research. Asked in May 2025 about the needs of middle-class elderly contemplating retirement on the mainland, it said it had not conducted any relevant surveys, and nor had other bureaux. The second is that the private market is not small, and is not waiting. 99,600 Hong Kong residents aged sixty-five and over were usually staying in Guangdong at mid-2024 — a record, up 40.5 per cent in ten years, about six per cent of all Hong Kong's elderly. 24,551 Hong Kong welfare recipients were living in the nine bay-area cities at the end of April 2025, 8,486 of them in Shenzhen alone.⁴

SOURCES 1 The Social Welfare Department's own scheme FAQ of 18 August 2026 and service brief of 6 May 2026, including the six-month trial, the inactive marking, the ending of the application and the two exclusion lists; the mainland requirements as set out in the same FAQ. 2 The Labour and Welfare Bureau's annex to a Legislative Council reply of 9 July 2025, giving the care-worker series for 31 December 2022, 2023, 2024 and 31 March 2025; the shares are our arithmetic from those figures. The importation scheme's start date from the same annex. 3 Place counts summed from the 2026–27 Estimates, Head 170; the central waiting list from the department's July 2026 statistics; the pilot-scheme figures and the home-by-home annex from the reply of 25 March 2026; the voucher comparison is ours against a reported eligible population; the 2026 Policy Address, paragraphs 390 to 393. 4 The Legislative Council Secretariat's statistical highlights of 21 May 2025, read through three outlets reporting it because the council's own server returned 503; a written reply of 21 May 2025 for the recipient counts; the monthly total is our arithmetic from the published rates and counts, not an official figure.

What does it feel like from inside? A Hong Kong paper sent a reporter into two Guangzhou homes in May last year, and the testimony is not what a critic would write. A couple of seventy-five, he a former senior railway employee, she from private finance, began planning in their forties, moved to Guangzhou in 2009 and entered a Huangpu district home in August 2023. Within four months they had found ten other Hong Kong residents in the building and started a group chat; the average age is eighty-two, which makes them, they joke, the young ones. On the staff: “Even your own children wouldn’t be this attentive.” They pay about RMB15,000 a month. On the alternative of emigrating west, he is dry: every country has its discrimination, and “a lot of your qualifications and experience, they just won’t recognise.”¹

Another couple, both eighty-nine, spent a year visiting fifteen homes before choosing one next to a new hospital campus, and paid a single lump sum covering twenty years. She tends a vegetable plot each morning: “having something to care for, I’m happier.” They lived in America for nearly thirty years and their descendants are still there, but — “in the end, fallen leaves return to the root.” And then the sentence that is the whole essay: “What we fear most is a serious illness — it could cost a million or more. In Hong Kong you wouldn’t have to worry about that.”¹

“What we fear most is a serious illness. In Hong Kong you wouldn’t have to worry about that.”

There it is. They have taken the home, the food, the nursing, the garden and the Cantonese-speaking carers across the boundary. The one thing they could not carry is the hospital. And the market has noticed: a June consumer guide to “avoiding the traps of retiring north” — the genre itself being the evidence that a market has matured — tells readers to insist on a ten-minute life circle to a tier-three hospital, on Hong Kong doctors and Hong Kong medicines, and on a direct Hong Kong shuttle downstairs, two hours at ninety yuan rather than

four hours at five hundred. The fear it names most bluntly, in four Cantonese characters, is dying without anyone knowing.²

So what is this? The useful precedent is not another ageing policy. It is the long history of portable entitlement — the moment a welfare state stops being a place and becomes a payment. Britain exported its old-age pension to retired colonists and then spent eighty years arguing about whether to uprate it abroad; the American Social Security Administration pays benefits into a hundred and fifty countries and has never once built a nursing home in one. What Hong Kong has done is the step past that. It is not merely sending the money across a boundary. It is contracting for the service on the other side, inspecting it, paying per occupied bed, and adjudicating the medical claims through an insurer. A columnist in a pro-establishment paper has already supplied the slogan: welfare should follow the person.³

Which is why the withheld number matters more than the headcount. If a Guangdong bed costs materially less than the HK\$18,809 Hong Kong pays at home, then every elder who crosses is a saving, the incentive runs one way, and “choice” is doing a great deal of quiet work — especially given a six-month clock that extinguishes the queue position behind you. If the gap is small, this really is just an option, and the empty beds and the sixteen applications are the honest measure of demand. The government knows which it is. It has told a legislator it is not suitable to say.⁴

Watch two things. The first is Macau, where a legislator in February asked the government to model its own mainland referral pilot on Hong Kong’s scheme, against a projection that over-sixty-fives will pass twenty-one per cent by 2029. The second is the adjacency nobody has remarked on: the insurer’s Hong Kong arm won the contract to adjudicate the scheme’s medical claims in December; a care home belonging to the same group joined the scheme two months later. Both facts are on the public record. Neither is an allegation.⁵

SOURCES 1 Sing Tao Headline, 21 May 2025, reporting from two Guangzhou care homes; all quotations are the reporter’s, translated here, and the residents are identified in the original only by surname. 2 A Hong Kong consumer guide of 25 June 2026, “eleven tips to avoid the traps of retiring north,” read at source. 3 The portable-pension history is general record; the columnist’s phrase from a Wen Wei Po opinion piece of 15 July 2026, page A17. 4 The unit cost from the 2026–27 Estimates, Head 170; the refusal from the reply of 25 March 2026. 5 A Macau legislator’s written interpellation of 27 February 2026, including the 2029 projection; the insurer’s appointment from the Social Welfare Department’s release of 17 December 2025 and the home’s accession date from the reply annex of 25 March 2026. The adjacency is stated as an observed fact from two official sources and nothing more.

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

The stand-in

A refinery burned outside Riyadh and the only witness either capital could produce was a French photographer. A headphone will sell you a score for your concentration from a company whose science page cites no study. A sovereign model was released by a company that had signed to become Canadian. Four hundred and eight Australian teenagers showed that a national ban moved daily use by nothing at all, while the regulator counted deleted accounts. Nine of the eleven basis points were real yield, not inflation. And four new restaurants opened in Singapore, all reviewed, none of them by anyone who paid.

Each of those is the same move. A thing that is hard to observe, and beside it a thing that is easy to count, standing in. METs for oxygen uptake. Accounts for safety. A signature for a provenance. A Metascore for a verdict. The stand-in is not a lie; it is usually the best available, and often it is all there is. The error is forgetting the substitution was made.

Bacon saw it in 1620, in the aphorism this issue opens with, and the sentence after it is the better one: the bonds of antiquity and authority leave us “unable, as if bewitched, to become familiar with things themselves.” Which is also why Hong Kong will not tell you what it pays for a bed in Guangdong (p25), and why that is the only number worth having.

A note on method. **Twelve Desks, One World** MERIDIAN No. 122, 4 October 2026
Headlines and leading figures were read where they stood. When the US Treasury's own price and real-time curves, downloaded as data rather than read as a page; the New York Fed's reference-rate interface; the Bureau of Labor Statistics' September employment and August price releases; the Federal Open Market Committee's September statement; Hong Kong's 2026–27 Budget estimates, four Legislative Council replies and the Social Welfare Department's own scheme documents; Singapore's environment agency real-time data interface at five o'clock this morning and the electricity tariff page; a 189-page model technical report, text-extracted from its own PDF; four llama.cpp pull requests with their review threads; the European Commission's own travel-authorisation page; Jigokudani Yaen-koen's own attendance register; Nagaden's and Alpico's published timetables and fare tables; and — computed here rather than quoted — fourteen seasons of base-area snowfall on p21, the fan running costs on p6, and the Hong Kong allowance total on p26. Corrections in this issue: three. BIGBANG plays the National Stadium, not the Indoor Stadium; My Chemical Romance is not sold out; and Post Malone is postponed, not cancelled — all on p23. We also carried “ETIAS, Q4 2026” unverified for several issues: there is no such date at the European source (p19). Refused this desk today: Reddit on every route, which is why five desks print a null result rather than a sentiment; Britmodeller, WatchUSeek (HTTP 402, payment required), Head-Fi, TripAdvisor, FlyerTalk, Scoot, JR East, Marina Bay Sands, Ticketmaster Singapore, Instagram, SETHLUI, the Straits Times, CNA and the Business Times at article level, eSafety Australia, the Legislative Council of Hong Kong, SingStat, the BMJ, ScienceDirect, Wikimedia's image host, and the environment agency's own haze site, which returned 503 on the morning the central region crossed one hundred.